

Ex-gardener held for ₹1 crore burglary in Pamposh Enclave

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's South District cracked a ₹1 crore burglary case within 48 hours of the complaint, arresting a 28-year-old habitual offender. The accused had been using his knowledge of residential colonies, gained during years of working as a gardener, to identify and target locked homes in upscale South Delhi neighbourhoods. The accused, Sanwara Gujjar alias Sunil, son of Harlal, a resident of Madanpur Khadar, originally

from Tonk district in Rajasthan, was arrested on May 22 following a raid by a joint team of Special Staff, South District, and Greater Kailash police station. He was also an absconder in a separate 2020 case, with non-bailable warrants issued against him by a court as recently as April 10, 2026. DCP South District Anant Mittal, IPS, confirmed the case was cracked through a combination of technical surveillance, local intelligence, and extensive CCTV analysis. "More than 250 CCTV cameras were scanned, and the movement of the accused

was tracked over nearly 10 kilometres, which proved crucial in identifying the offender," Mittal said. The burglary was reported on May 20 at Pamposh Enclave under the jurisdiction of Greater Kailash police station. The complainant returned home at night to find the locks broken and the house ransacked. Gold, diamond, and silver jewellery worth approximately ₹1 crore and cash of ₹6.5 lakh had been stolen. An FIR was registered, and an investigation was launched immediately. Two teams were constituted on the same night.



Within 48 hours, on May 22, the teams acted on specific intelligence and arrested Sanwara Gujjar. During interrogation, he confessed and led the police to the stolen goods. The recoveries were significant. A diamond watch worth ₹12 lakh, a diamond solitaire ring, earrings, a Tag Heuer watch worth ₹3 lakh, and a moon bracelet were among the jewellery retrieved. Cash of ₹3.57 lakh was also recovered. The remaining ₹2.93 lakh of the stolen cash has not been accounted for, suggesting some money was spent or

concealed before the arrest. The modus operandi speaks to a methodical criminal operation. Sanwara would conduct reconnaissance of residential colonies during daytime hours, specifically identifying homes that remained locked through the day, indicating the occupants were out. He would then carry out the break-in using house-breaking tools and immediately shift hideouts afterwards. The stolen jewellery was moved quickly through local contacts to prevent recovery. His background as a gar-

dener who had worked inside residential homes in similar colonies gave him an advantage in identifying targets and understanding the routines of affluent households in South Delhi. Sanwara is a school dropout with one prior case registered against him at the New Friends Colony police station in 2020. He had been absconding in that case and was a wanted accused at the time of this arrest. South District Police said it remains committed to zero tolerance against organised burglary and habitual property offenders.

Elderly watchman dies after being run over twice by SUV in Peeragarhi village

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 60-year-old watchman was on Sunday assaulted by an SUV driver and then run over twice when he tried to escape, leading to his death in outer Delhi's Peeragarhi village, with CCTV footage capturing the chilling sequence of events, according to police.

The deceased was identified as Bijender Bharadwaj, a resident of the village, who worked as a watchman at the tempo stand where the incident occurred. An analysis of CCTV footage indicated that the victim may have been deliberately targeted, a police officer said, adding that they were probing all angles. In the CCTV footage, the vehicle can be seen waiting in one corner with its headlights on for a few minutes while the victim was sitting on a chair in the opposite direction. A man then stepped out of the vehicle carrying a large stick and started attacking the victim without any apparent provocation. As the victim tried to save himself, the accused returned to the SUV



and ran him over once, pushing him towards a corner. When the victim attempted to escape, the accused again drove the vehicle towards him and ran him over a second time before swiftly fleeing the spot. The police said skid marks were also found at the spot during inspection, indicating that the vehicle had braked before or during the incident. The police said a PCR call regarding the incident was received at around 4.03 am on Sunday, following which the local team rushed to the spot. Bijender was found lying unconscious on the road and was rushed to a nearby hospi-

tal, where he was declared dead. A case under sections 103(1) (murder) and 3(5) (common intentions) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) has been registered at Paschim Vihar West police station. The vehicle fled the scene after the incident, the police said, adding that efforts are underway to ascertain its registration number and ownership details. "Detailed scrutiny of CCTV footage installed in and around the area revealed that the deceased was run over twice by a four-wheeler. The footage is being examined thoroughly to identify the vehicle and reconstruct the exact sequence of events

and what led to the matter," the officer said. Multiple teams have been deployed to trace the accused driver and the vehicle involved, the police said. Forensic and other teams inspected the scene and collected forensic and technical evidence. Meanwhile, a relative of the victim said he had had no enmity or dispute with anyone. "We came to know about the incident around 3.30 pm. My uncle has been working here as a security guard for the past one year. He was a simple man and had no enmity or dispute with anyone. Anyone here can tell you that he never fought with anybody," Sunil Bhardwaj, a nephew of the victim, said. "The police reached the spot and checked the CCTV footage, but the vehicle's number plate is not visible in the footage," he said. The police said they are scanning CCTV footage from nearby roads, traffic intersections and commercial establishments to track the movement of the SUV before and after the incident.

Capital logs maximum temperature of 43.6°C, yellow alert for heatwave for next three days

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 43.6 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above the seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). The minimum temperature settled at 28.4 degrees Celsius on Sunday morning, two notches above the seasonal average, it stated. The maximum temperature across various weather stations in Delhi-NCR remained significantly above normal on Sunday, with the Ridge and Ayanagar stations recording the highest temperature at 44.6 degrees Celsius each. Lodhi Road recorded a maximum temperature of 43.8 degrees Celsius, followed by Palam at 43.7 degrees Celsius and Safdarjung at 43.6 degrees Celsius. The departure from normal ranged between 2.3 degrees Celsius and 4.8 degrees Celsius, indicating prevailing heatwave-like conditions in several parts of the city. Meanwhile, the minimum



A traffic police personnel uses an electric hand fan and AC helmet on a summer day in New Delhi on Sunday

temperature also stayed above normal at most stations. Safdarjung recorded a minimum temperature of 28.7 degrees Celsius, while Ridge registered 27.2 degrees Celsius and Palam 27.6 degrees Celsius. Lodhi Road and Ayanagar recorded minimum temperatures of 26.8 degrees Celsius and 26.3 degrees Celsius, respectively. The departures

from normal minimum temperatures ranged from minus 0.4 degrees Celsius to plus 2 degrees Celsius. The weather department has predicted a yellow alert for strong surface winds and a heatwave in the afternoon and evening for the next three days. The maximum and minimum temperatures are expected to hover around 44

and 30 degrees Celsius, respectively, on Monday. Relative humidity oscillated between 37 per cent and 18 per cent throughout the day. The air quality was recorded in the 'poor' category at 4 pm, with an Air Quality Index (AQI) reading of 205, Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data showed.

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu praises Gurindervir Singh after record sprint

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday congratulated sprinter Gurindervir Singh after the athlete clocked 10.09 seconds in the 100 metres to become the fastest Indian runner in the event. In a message posted on social media, Sandhu described the achievement as a his-

toric moment for Indian athletics and praised the athlete's discipline, focus, and dedication. Gurindervir Singh's timing of 10.09 seconds is being seen as a major milestone for Indian sprinting. The performance established him as the country's fastest man and drew praise from several public figures and sports supporters. Reacting to the achieve-

ment, the Lieutenant Governor said the sprinter's success would inspire young athletes across the country. Sandhu said Gurindervir's journey reflected the importance of determination and consistent hard work in achieving excellence at the national and international level. Calling the sprint performance "phenomenal," the Lieutenant Governor said the athlete had created a



proud moment for the country through his record-breaking run. He also wished Gurindervir success in future competitions and expressed hope that the sprinter would continue delivering strong performances on the international stage. Sandhu said he hoped the athlete would win medals for India and continue setting new records in

global competitions. The Lieutenant Governor's remarks came shortly after Gurindervir Singh's performance attracted widespread attention among athletics followers and sports enthusiasts. Indian athletics has witnessed growing interest in sprint events in recent years, with athletes increasingly achieving competitive timings at national and inter-

national meets. In his message, Sandhu said the athlete's achievement represented the spirit of commitment and perseverance that young sportspersons should aspire to follow. The Lieutenant Governor also said Gurindervir's success had brought pride to the nation and highlighted the growing strength of Indian athletics.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Chole Mukta Sugreev, W/o No.16018555M Hav Chole Balaji Venkat Rao, R/o- At Kolnoor, PO- Malikpurga, TQ-Jalkot, Dist- Latur, Maharashtra have changed my daughter's name from Chole Kartiki to Chole Kartiki Balaji, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1160)C

I, No.16018555M Hav Chole Balaji Venkat Rao, R/o- At Kolnoor, PO- Malikpurga, TQ-Jalkot, Dist- Latur, Maharashtra have changed my daughter's name from Chole Vaibhavi to Chole Vaibhavi Balaji, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1161)C

I, No.15724564A L/Hav Vinod Kumar, R/o- P 482/1, Mohan Enclave Delhi Cantt- 110010 declare that in my service record, my father's name is wrongly recorded as Sukh Pal Singh whereas his correct name is Sukh Pal which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1162)C

I, Rathod Radhika Suresh, W/o- JC-708002M Sub Rathod Suresh Dasu R/o- A/P- Borgaon, Tal- Koregaon, Dist- Satara, Maharashtra- 415511, have changed my name from Rathod Radhika Suresh to Radhika Suresh Rathod vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1163)C

PD(1156)C

I, Gudiya Devi spouse of JC- 675406M Sub/Clk(SD) Vijai Chandra, presently residing at- Vill- Kodai, PO- Kodai, Teh- Harraiya, Distt- Basti (U.P.), have changed my name from Godia Devi to Gudiya Devi, vide affidavit dated 22/05/2026 before Notary District Court Pithoragarh (UK)

PD(1157)C

I, Bhagirath Singh Jadoun, F/o- JC-473056H Sub Raghvendra Singh, R/o- Vill & Post- Udotgarh, Teh- Attair, Dist- Bhind, M.P.- 477111, have changed my name from Bhagirath Singh Jadoun to Bhagirath Singh, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1158)C

I, Bhanumati Devi, M/o- JC- 473056H Sub Raghvendra Singh, R/o- Vill & Post- Udotgarh, Teh- Attair, Dist- Bhind, M.P.- 477111, have changed my name from Bhanumati Devi to Bhanmati vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1159)C

I, MES-376284 Elect(SK) Balbir Singh R/o- C-120-C Tilak Vihar, New Delhi- 110018, declare that in my service record my Mother's name is wrongly recorded as Shanti Indra Kaur whereas her correct name is Indra Kaur, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(1164)C

I, Nirmala Devi Mother of- No.10136639M Hav Sohan Singh, R/o- VPO- Patti Kalyana, Teh- Samalkha, Dist- Panipat, Haryana- 132102, have changed my name from Nirmala Devi to Nirmla, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1165)C

I, Priyanka Devi W/o- No.10136639M Hav Sohan Singh, R/o- VPO- Patti Kalyana, Teh- Samalkha, Dist- Panipat, Haryana- 132102, have changed my name from Priyanka Devi to Priyanka, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1166)C

I, JC-708002M Sub Rathod Suresh Dasu, R/o- A/P- Borgaon, Tal- Koregaon, Dist- Satara, Maharashtra- 415511, have changed my daughter's name from Rathod Arushi Suresh to Arushi Suresh Rathod, vide affidavit dated 23/05/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(1167)C

NOTICE

FORM NO. INC-26

(Pursuant to rule 30 the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014)

BEFORE REGIONAL DIRECTOR (NORTHERN REGION), DELHI

In the matter of the Companies Act, 2013, Section 13(4) of Companies Act, 2013 and Rule 30(6) (a) of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014

AND

In the matter of TEVRIZ INFRABUILDTECH (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED having its registered office at C/O, RZ-2520, Flat No - D, Gali No. 27-28, Tughlakabad Extension, South Delhi, New Delhi, India, 110019 Petitioner

Notice is hereby given to the General Public that the company proposes to make application to the Central Government under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 seeking confirmation of alteration of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of the special resolution passed at the Extra ordinary general meeting held on 15.05.2026 to enable the company to change its Registered office from "Union Territory of Delhi" to "State of Assam".

Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of the registered office of the company may deliver either on the MCA-21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or send by registered post of his/her objections supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Regional Director, NORTHERN REGION at the address B-2 Wing, 2nd floor, Pt. Deendayal Antyodaya Bhawan, 2nd floor, CGO Complex, New Delhi - 110003 within fourteen days of the date of publication of this notice with a copy to the applicant company at its registered office.

For and on behalf of FOR TEVRIZ INFRABUILDTECH (OPC) PRIVATE LIMITED

Sd/-

SHARIF UDDIN SARKAR DIRECTOR DIN:08228200

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Naresh Kumar, S/o Late Shri Lekh Raj, R/o House No. 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005 the co-owner of the property bearing number 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005. In terms of the consented decree passed on 10.03.2025 in case PC 4225/16 by the court of Shri. Ramesh Malik, District Judge -06, Central Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi, I and other parties are going to sale out the property in question i.e. property bearing No. 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005, Kharsa Number 2439 measuring about 50 Sq. Yards to any third party. I state that this property bearing No. 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005, Kharsa Number 2439 measuring about 50 Sq Yards is free from any charge and is free from all sorts of defects in the title of the said property. Any person(s), bank, financial institution, or entity having any claim, right, title, interest, or objection over the Said Property-including through sale, inheritance, gift, lease, mortgage, or otherwise-are hereby required to make their claims known in writing along with supporting documentary evidence to the deponent at the address mentioned within 7 days from the date of publication of this Failing to intimate any such claim within the stipulated period, the negotiations for the sale will be completed without any reference to such claims. Any claims thereafter shall be deemed to have been waived, abandoned, and or waived to all intents and purpose.

Regards Naresh Kumar, S/o Late Shri Lekh Raj, R/o House No. 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005 the co-owner of the property bearing number 3798 Gali No.21, Regarpura, Karol Bagh, Delhi 110005.

ARIAS SOCIETY

(An Autonomous Body of the Govt, of Assam)

Project Management Unit of the Asian Development Bank financed Assam Sustainable Wetland and Integrated Fisheries Transformation (SWIFT) Project Agriculture Complex, Khanapara, G.S. Road, Guwahati-781022 (Assam, India)

INVITATION FOR BIDS (IFB)

The Government of Assam through the Government of India has applied for a loan from the Asian Development Bank for the proposed Assam SWIFT project. The ARIAS Society now intends to apply a portion of the loan for the Conservation, Restoration and Rejuvenation works for the following Beels.

SN	Name of Beel	District	IFB No.
1.	Nayachara Beel	Bongaigaon	ARIAS /ADB-SWIFT/CW10-57
2.	Borai Pani Khowa Beel	Bongaigaon	ARIAS /ADB-SWIFT/CW 10-58
3.	Singra Beel	Dhubri	ARIAS /ADB-SWIFT/CW 10-63

Interested bidders may download and submit their bids electronically using the e-Procurement portal <https://assamtenders.gov.in/>.

Sd/- State Project Director, ARIAS Society

DIPR/CF/PIO/225/25-May-26

Police bust Nandu Gang extortion plot, five held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police's Special Cell has arrested three alleged sharpshooters linked to the Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu gang and two suspected weapon suppliers in connection with a planned extortion firing at a clinic in southwest Delhi's Chhawla area. Police said the accused were allegedly sent by gangster Kapil Sangwan to open fire at the clinic to threaten the owner for extortion. The planned attack, however, could not be carried out after the accused found a heavy public presence near the target location. Three semi-automatic pistols, four live cartridges, and three mobile phones were recovered from the accused, police said. Deputy Commissioner of Police Narra Chaitanya of the Northern Range, Special Cell, said the arrests had dealt a major blow to the extortion network allegedly being operated by the gang. "With this operation, Delhi Police has successfully foiled a major planned firing incident for extortion in the capital," the officer said. Police said the Special Cell had been tracking organised criminal gangs involved in extortion and targeted attacks in Delhi-NCR through technical surveillance and intelligence gathering. According to investigators, specific

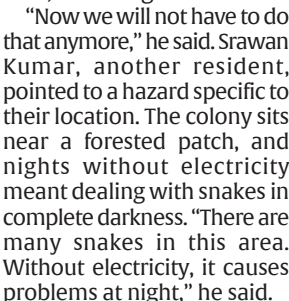
inputs were received that Punjab-based shooters had been recruited by Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu for a firing incident in Delhi. After more than a month of surveillance and source development, police identified the suspects who had allegedly conducted reconnaissance of the clinic in February 2026. On March 20, the police team arrested Abhishek, a resident of Amritsar in Punjab. During questioning, he allegedly revealed details of the planned attack and named his associates. Police later arrested Sahil and Harshdeep alias Polu, both from Amritsar, along with Karan alias Ankush and Aman from Kaithal in Haryana. Investigators said Harshdeep was allegedly in direct contact with Kapil Sangwan and had recruited the other shooters for the planned firing. Police claimed that the gang members had travelled to Delhi earlier this year after arrangements for weapons, ammunition, and a motorcycle were made through associates based in Kaithal.



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

■ New Delhi

North-East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari was also present at the occasion. The story of how these families spent eight years without power carries details that are difficult to read without a sense of what



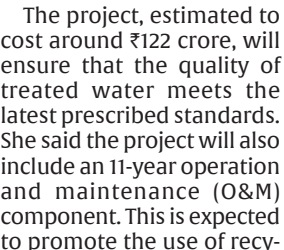
She directed officials immediately to coordinate among

For the families of Harsh Vihar's A-3 block, the wait lasted eight years. The poles went up on Sunday morning. The power is coming in two to three days. Bhagwati Pathak was at the Jan Seva Sadan to say thank you before it had even arrived.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

■ New Delhi

In addition, four DSTPs will be established at Kair, Kanganheri, Kakrola and Dichaon Kalan, three DSTPs at Galibpur, Sarangpur and Shikarpur, and four DSTPs at Hasanpur, Jaffarpur, Kazipur and Khera Dabar. These projects will benefit more than



The chief minister that a major trunk sewer line from Amichand Chowk to the Old Kalyanpuri Sewage Pumping Station in the Trilokpuri Assembly constituency will

She also congratulated Delhi Jal Board officials, engineers, field staff and public representatives for these important projects and decisions.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

highways, and accident-prone stretches. During the

a dangerous offence that risks lives, causes fatal acci-

seen on busy roads, highways, and narrow stretches

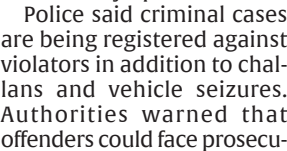
tion and other strict legal action if caught driving such violations not only

■ New Delhi

Police said the special campaign was carried out across Delhi on May 22 and May 23 at major roads, intersections,

“Wrong-side driving is not merely a traffic violation. It is

Officials said wrong-side driving has increasingly become one of the major causes of head-on collisions and traffic disorder in the city. The practice is commonly



delivery vehicles. Officials stated that many drivers continue to ignore traffic rules despite repeated awareness campaigns and warnings from authorities.

The department appealed to citizens to use only lawful routes and avoid taking illegal shortcuts for convenience.

The club has been an important part of our lives for decades, and run by a Government-appointed committee following direct



The club has urged the Centre to ensure that there is "no dislocation" of the club and its operations. The members of the club met on Sunday and launched a signature campaign to authorise legal action against the

Brigadier Harinder Pal Bedi (retd), a long-time member of Delhi Gymkhana, said that the members met on Sunday and signed an authorisation letter to file a petition against the order on Monday. "Several members of the club have signed the plea, and more are expected to sign it by tonight."

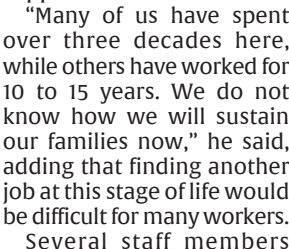
The club is currently being

The Secretary said that the club members have decided to write to the Land & Development Office (L&DO) of the ministry, as the issue involves the interests of the members and employees of the Club. The Officiating Secretary said in a statement, "Pursuant to the sudden development, the GC today met on an urgent basis and after detailed deliberation decided to write an immediate response to L&DO requesting clarity on several issues in the interest of the members and employees of the Club."

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

■ New Delhi

"We were told about the development yesterday. Staff members have been calling me throughout the night, asking what will happen to them and where they will go," Negi said.



"I am old now and have dedicated my entire life to this work. Our 'jhuggi' is also set to be demolished on May 26. First, our home, and now our job - how are we going to

He mentioned that the committee members had held a meeting after receiving the notice and decided to challenge the order in court.

The club premises, located at 2 Safdarjung Road in Lutyens' Delhi, were originally leased to the Imperial Delhi Gymkhana Club Ltd, now known as the Delhi Gymkhana Club, for operating a social and sporting institution.

CBC 19108/13/0116/2627

IN FOCUS



Fishermen steer a fishing boat through sea waves at the Valiyathura coast near Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala

PTI

Assam Police busts interstate terror funding network; 5 held

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Tinsukia (Assam)

Assam Police has unearthed a suspected interstate terror funding network and arrested five people, including a students' union leader here and an accused in Maharashtra, officials said on Sunday.

They said investigations are on to ascertain the motive behind the extortion and funding network, and the organisation for which the funds were being collected.

Addressing a joint press conference here, additional superintendent of police (HQ) Mrinmoy Das and Dinesh Pratap Singh Rathore, Crime Branch, said intelligence inputs



were received from a central agency that extorted money from Tinsukia district was being channelled outside the region.

During the investigation, the name of one Debashish Gohain, working as a journalist with a news portal, surfaced, following which he was apprehended.

India, US signal reset in strained ties

"Let me State India's broad position... And I would make five points here. One, that we advocate dialogue and diplomacy to address conflicts. Two, we support safe and unimpeded maritime commerce," Jaishankar said.

"Three, we demand scrupulous respect for international law. Fourth, we are against the weaponisation of market shares and resources. And five, we believe in the value of trusted partnerships and resilient supply chains to de-risk the global economy," he said.

In the talks, Jaishankar forcefully mentioned how the West Asia crisis has significantly hit India's energy security and brought economic woes, people familiar with the matter said.

The external affairs minister also underlined the importance for India to have multiple sources of energy, emphasising that the energy market should not be "distorted".

Jaishankar said India is one of the very few countries that have very good relations with the United States, Israel, Iran and the Gulf countries. The external affairs minister said India is very much in favour of safe and unimpeded maritime commerce in the Strait of Hormuz.

Citing a fragile geopolitical situation, Jaishankar said India has very strong relations with the US, Russia, Europe, Ukraine and countries around the world. The external affairs minister also flagged India's concerns with Rubio over the Trump administration's changes to visa and immigration policies, saying legal mobility should not be adversely impacted by the new approach.

The US Secretary of State acknowledged that there could be "some bumps" and "friction points" in the period of transition as the US is trying to improve the immigration system, but ultimately, an "efficient" framework will be helpful to every stakeholder. The Secretary of State assured that the current process to reform the immigration system is not targeted at India at all. Answering a question on economic ties, Rubio said India and the US are poised to soon firm up the much-awaited trade agreement that will be both "beneficial" and "sustainable" and would advance the mutual interests of both nations.

To a question on Washington's increasingly warm ties with Pakistan and China, Rubio said: "As far as our relations with other countries are concerned, we have relations, and we work at the tactical level in many ways with countries all over the world, so does India, like every other responsible nation."

Ebola outbreak: Avoid travel to affected...

According to the advisory issued by the Indian Government on Saturday, the WHO's IHR Emergency Committee on May 22 issued temporary recommendations to strengthen disease surveillance at points of entry to "detect, assess, report and manage travellers with unexplained febrile illness arriving from areas with documented Bundibugyo virus detection" while discouraging travel to the affected regions.

Countries bordering the DRC and Uganda, including South Sudan, have been assessed to be at high risk of disease transmission, the advisory said. "The Government of India advises all its citizens to avoid non-essential travel to the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Uganda

Democracy under threat in Andhra Pradesh: Jagan Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amaravati

YSRCP supremo YS Jagan Mohan Reddy on Sunday alleged that democracy in Andhra Pradesh was under threat and accused Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu of using police machinery to "suppress" opposition voices and dissent.

There was no immediate response from the ruling TDP. In a post on X, Jagan said, "Democracy in Andhra Pradesh is under grave threat because of Naidu's politics of suppression and intimidation... Acting like a dictator, he (the CM) has turned the state into a police raj where opposition leaders, journalists and social media activists who



question the Government are being systematically silenced."

The opposition leader also condemned the alleged police action against YSRCP leaders Jogi Ramesh, Jupudi Prabhakar, Varikuti Ashok Babu, Peeta Naga Mohan Krishna, Ambati Murali and others who were travelling to Mamillapalli village in Ponnur

constituency of Guntur district to express solidarity with Kapu community farmers.

According to him, the (YSRCP) leaders were manhandled, arrested and treated like criminals for raising issues concerning farmers and questioning the Government.

The alleged police action

reflected what he described as the Government's attempt to curb peaceful protests and discourage criticism.

Raising concern over farmers' distress, the former CM alleged that maize farmers had suffered losses after being forced to sell produce below the remunerative price.

While the remunerative price for maize stood at ₹2,400, farmers had sold produce between ₹1,400 and ₹1,600 this season, causing financial distress, he added.

He further alleged that some farmers belonging to Kapu community, who stored maize in warehouses anticipating better prices were targeted and that cases under the SC/ST Act were registered against them.

Puri Jagannath temple postpones Ratna Bhandar inventory work to June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Puri

The Shree Jagannath Temple authorities in Puri have decided to postpone the ongoing inventory of valuables in the 'Ratna Bhandar' of the 12th-century shrine till June in view of the prevailing hot and humid weather in this seaside holy town and 'Chandan Jatra' (summer festival) rituals.

Though the temple administration had earlier decided to hold inventory work for four more days on May 26, 28, 29 and 30, it has been decided to suspend inventory work in these days, Chief Administrator of Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (SJTA), Arabinda Padhee, told reporters.

He said that apart from the continuing heatwave conditions, heavy footfall of devotees and preparations for the upcoming 'Snan Purnima' festival, the



administration decided to keep the inventory work stopped for some days.

"We are not in a hurry. The objective is to undertake a flawless and transparent inventory of the Lord's Ratna Bhandar inventory," Padhee said, adding that the swelling crowd of devotees in the temple could create operational challenges.

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the Strait of Hormuz would gradually reopen in parallel with the US ending its blockade of Iran's ports, the officials said.

The US would allow Iran to sell its oil through sanctions waivers, said the second official, who has been briefed on the negotiations. Sanctions relief and the release of Iran's frozen funds would be negotiated during the 60-day time frame, the official said. Both officials said the draft deal includes an end to the war between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon, as well as a commitment to not interfere in the domestic affairs of countries in the region.

Twelve weeks have passed since the US and Israel attacked Iran, killing its supreme leader and other top officials. A ceasefire with Iran has held since April 7, though the sides have exchanged fire on occasion.

Several countries, including the European Union and the United Kingdom, welcomed progress on a possible deal with Iran.

Israel is concerned about Hezbollah Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warned Trump that Israel maintains freedom of action against threats in all arenas, including Lebanon, according to an official familiar with the conversation. The official spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media.

The official said Trump made it clear to Netanyahu that he would not sign any final agreement without the conditions that Iran dismantle its entire nuclear program and give up all its enriched uranium.

Israel's Science Minister Gila Gamliel, a member of Netanyahu's Likud party and part of his national security cabinet, told Israel's Army Radio that Israel is taking a "wait-and-see" approach. Israeli officials are concerned that Hezbollah remains a serious threat to Israel and that Lebanon is ill-equipped to disarm it.

A fragile, US-brokered ceasefire took effect in Lebanon on April 17, but fighting has continued, mainly in the south. Hezbollah has launched daily drone and rocket attacks on Israeli forces and northern Israel, and Israel has struck targets across Lebanon while its troops remain in large swaths of the south.

More than 3,000 people have been killed in the latest round of fighting, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry. Additionally, 22 Israeli soldiers and a defence contractor have been killed in or near southern Lebanon, and two civilians have been killed in northern Israel, according to Netanyahu's office. (AP)

Delhi's shopping problem just became a business

The chair detail is one of the more striking features of the service. Assistants carry portable foldable camping chairs that can be set up anywhere in the market when a customer needs to rest. Alongside this, the package includes umbrellas for heat and rain, mobile charging support, power banks, and hydration assistance. "People love shopping, but they hate the physical exhaustion that comes with it," a person associated with a startup said. "We wanted shoppers to enjoy the experience instead of worrying about ten bags while navigating a crowded market."

The service has also found a specific use among customers who face particular physical challenges in a market environment. Pregnant women have booked the service to manage the difficulty of carrying weight while moving

He said the inventory process will resume in June after reviewing weather conditions and logistical requirements.

"Since the 'Bitara Chandan Jatra' (inner summer festival) will be underway, strategy for the next phase of the inventory process will be decided in consultation with servitor's association and other related sub-committees," Padhee told reporters. As the inventory work is kept in abeyance for some days, the devotees can now have darshan of the sibling deities – Lord Balabhadra, Devi Subhadra and Lord Jagannath – from 'Bhitara Katha' (inner barricade) inside the 'Jagamohan', just outside the sanctum sanctorum.

Earlier, the darshan was available to the devotees only from the 'Bahara Katha' (outer barricade) in view of the security considerations during the inventory process.

through crowds. Parents with toddlers have used it when managing both a stroller and shopping became unmanageable. The startup offers stroller rentals alongside the assistant service at an additional hourly charge.

The assistant carries a maximum of 12 kg. Beyond that, a second assistant can be hired.

For now, operations are limited to Lajpat Nagar. Expansion to Chandni Chowk is already in planning. The logic of extending to Chandni Chowk, one of Delhi's oldest and most labyrinthine markets, is straightforward: if Lajpat Nagar is physically demanding, Chandni Chowk is another category entirely.

The social media response to CarryMen has been significant, split between those who see it as a practical urban solution and those who have raised questions about privilege and the ethics of paid physical labour in a market context. The debate has, if anything, accelerated the startup's visibility.

What is harder to argue with is the gap it is filling. Delhi's famous markets have not changed in any fundamental way. The bags are still heavy. The crowds are still dense. The heat in May is still brutal. Someone eventually had to notice that the exhaustion at the end of a shopping trip was itself a problem worth solving. They are charging ₹149 an hour for the answer.

BJP sweeps Falta repoll, wins by one lakh votes

The result came days after the BJP ended the TMC's 15-year rule and scripted a regime change in West Bengal earlier this month, lending the Falta contest significance far beyond the boundaries of South 24 Parganas and turning it into an early test of the State's altered political landscape.

With the Falta victory, the BJP's tally in Election Commission records for the 2026 Assembly polls rose to 208 from 207, though its effective Assembly strength remained 207 after Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari vacated Nandigram upon retaining Bhabanipur. Adhikari described the verdict as proof that "reality had come to light" when people were allowed to vote freely.

Promising to repay the "debt through development" and build a "golden Falta", he launched a sharp attack on the TMC, alleging that the party, while in power, had transformed itself into a "mafia company" that abused state machinery, looted public funds and fostered a culture of syndicates and intimidation.

The result also cast a shadow over what the TMC had long projected as the politically impregnable "Diamond Harbour model", as the BJP sought to convert a local repoll into a larger political message.

The Assembly constituency had become the centre of controversy after the April 29 polling when complaints surfaced over alleged use of perfume-like substances, ink marks and adhesive tapes on EVMs at multiple booths. The Election Commission ordered a repoll in all 285 booths on May 21, held under an unprecedented security blanket.

CBSE fee fiasco: Pradhan seeks FM help

Pradhan has also directed to depute teams of professors and technical experts from IIT-Madras and IIT-Kanpur to examine all the technical issues reported since the rollout of this

Maharashtra's Brahmapuri hottest in country at 47.2 degrees

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several states grappled with scorching heat on Sunday, with Brahmapuri in the Vidarbha region of Maharashtra emerging as the hottest place in the country at 47.2 degrees Celsius, according to the Indian Meteorological Department.

The weather office, however, forecast gradual relief from the heat from May

Celsius, 4.6 notches above normal, making it the hottest place in the country.

Several other places in the region also saw mercury hovering around 45 degrees Celsius. Chandrapur saw mercury soaring to 45.6 degrees, Wardha registering 45.5 degrees, Nagpur 45.4 degrees, Amraoti 45.2 degrees, and Gondia recording 45 degrees Celsius. In Rajasthan, temperatures hovered between 45 and 46 degrees Celsius.



29. "Heat wave to severe heat wave conditions are expected to persist over Central & Northwest India during the next 7 days, and over East & adjoining Peninsular India for the next 3-5 days," the IMD said in its forecast.

Delhi recorded a maximum temperature of 43.6 degrees Celsius, 3.4 notches above the seasonal average.

Ayanagar and the Ridge weather stations recorded 44.6 degrees Celsius each, followed by Lodhi Road at 43.8 degrees, Palam at 43.7 degrees and Safdarjung at 43.6 degrees Celsius.

In Maharashtra, Brahmapuri in the Vidarbha region saw temperature soaring to 47.2 degrees

Sri Ganganagar was the hottest place in Rajasthan at 46 degrees Celsius, the meteorological department said.

Vanasthali was the second hottest place in the state at 45.1 degrees Celsius, followed by 44.9 degrees in Churu, and 44.8 degrees each in Kota, Phalodi, Bikaner, and Jaipur at 43.6 degrees Celsius.

The Jaipur meteorological centre in Jaipur issued a heatwave alert, warning that weather conditions are likely to remain dry across most parts of the state for the next three to four days.

The department further said that on May 26 and 27, mercury in some parts of western Rajasthan may reach 46-47 degrees Celsius.

year's re-evaluation services and assist the CBSE in ensuring a glitch-free process, the education ministry said.

"The team of experts will implement focused technological improvements and will specifically examine portal stability and server performance. The team will also examine the overall IT Infrastructure and assist in taking corrective measures to ensure that login authentication/user access systems/payment gateways are accurate and in order," it added.

According to the statement, Pradhan reiterated that "student interests remain paramount" and that all necessary corrective measures need to be undertaken by the CBSE on priority to ensure a "transparent, efficient and student-friendly system".

CBSE will engage experts from the Indian Institute of Technology, Madras and IIT-Kanpur to address technical challenges in its post-result services portal. The move comes amid complaints from students and parents over glitches in the CBSE re-evaluation process. On Saturday, Pradhan also sought a detailed report from the CBSE over complaints of technical glitches faced by students during the re-evaluation process. The minister took serious cognisance of issues related to server downtime, payment gateway glitches and operational lapses reported during the process, sources said.

UCC will not affect tribals: Amit Shah

"I want to tell everyone spreading confusion that the UCC will not interfere with the traditions and customs of any tribal or Vanvasi brother or sister," he said. "Take this message to every village, every region, the hills and forests, and make every tribal community aware that there is no need to fear the UCC," Shah added. Referring to Naxalism, Shah said the country is moving towards becoming free from the problem and claimed tribal development has suffered for decades due to violence.

"Today, in this Kumbh of tribal communities, I can proudly say that our country is moving towards becoming fully free from the Naxal problem," he said.

"Those who stalled the development of tribal society through violence caused the deaths of thousands of tribal people. We are now moving completely out of that crisis. Now the time has come for rapid development in tribal regions, hills and forests," Shah added.

The home minister also spoke against religious conversions in tribal areas and said no one has the right to forcibly convert another person's faith. "Our Constitution makers gave every individual the right to live with dignity according to their original faith and traditions. No greed, temptation or inducement should be used to change anyone's religion," Shah said.

"Those who are trying to create divisions should understand that today's gathering of tribal communities sends a very strong message to them," he said, adding that tribal communities have remained deeply connected to nature worship and traditional beliefs. Shah also attacked previous Congress governments over tribal welfare spending and claimed that the Modi government has significantly increased the budget for the community.

"Earlier, the total budget for tribal welfare was only ₹28,000 crore. Narendra Modi ji increased it to ₹1.54 lakh crore," he said.

GRAPEVINE

Perform or perish

The Union Council of Ministers meeting last week was not merely for review and presentations. During the key meeting at Seva Teerth, first the Cabinet Secretary made a brief presentation of overall governance and achievements of 12 years of the Modi Government, followed by detailed presentations by nine key ministries on governance priorities, reforms, and future action plans toward Viksit Bharat 2047. Briefings were being done by the concerned department secretaries, but the grapevine has it that at least six ministers, including four Cabinet Ministers, came into the line of fire of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. While three Cabinet members were named and pointed at, one of them, considered to be the cynosure of the ruling party, was just shown annoyance by the PM. The message was loud and clear: perform or perish, confided a member of the high-profile meeting and shared that they could not even take a sip of water after that rebuke, forget about dinner.



After Gymkhana, which ‘Khan Market Gang’?

After the Gymkhana Club got notice from the Government for eviction, the talk of the town is which club is next on the Government's radar. On Saturday night, several clubs' management had a meeting on settling the dues, clarifications sought by the Ministry of Urban Development. Many clubs are headed by retired top officers, and no one was properly replying to queries from the Government regarding auditing, dues, etc. Some of them say the next is expected to be another high-profile golf club in the Lutyens', a few say the Government want several clubs in the vicinity of Central Vista to move out. Couple of them have already been allotted land for moving out, but have expressed their continuous reluctance.



Prashant Kishor to contest elections!

Struggling to carve a niche in caste-ridden Bihar politics, Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor seems not to have given up and continues to make a buzz about his political aspirations in the state, mostly through media and social media platforms. Now that Nitish Kumar has called it a day in state politics, the grapevine has it that Prashant Kishor may take an electoral plunge from Patna's high-profile Bankipore seat, which has been vacated by BJP President Nitin Nabin after his election to the Rajya Sabha. This is being considered to send the right message and hence keep engaged the workers who have come into the party fold, as the next elections are a long time away. One of his close aides said Prashant is now a bit tizzy as the BJP regime has taken over, and there is a probability of the JDU splitting/breaking away. Once upon a time the poll strategist was close to Nitish as well as the BJP.



Punjab: Three children drown after family jumps into canal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patiala

A Mohali-based couple along with their three minor children allegedly jumped into a canal near Rajpura on Sunday, police said.

While locals rescued the couple, the three children – two girls and a boy – drowned after being swept away by the strong current.

The incident occurred about one kilometre ahead of the Mandoli bridge near Rajpura. Police said the reason behind the family allegedly jumping into the

canal is yet to be ascertained. Villagers rushed to the spot after noticing the incident and managed to pull the couple out safely. However, the children were carried away by the water.

A team of local divers later recovered the bodies of three children, identified as Ekam (7), Rajvir (12), and Muskan (14). The family belongs to Mojpur village near Landran in Mohali district.

The bodies have been sent to the Civil Hospital in Rajpura for post-mortem examination, while further investigation is underway, police said.

Ladakh talks with Centre positive step, says Wangchuk

ANJALI OJHA
■ New Delhi

The recent talks between Ladakh representatives and the Centre marked a “positive step”, activist Sonam Wangchuk said, though he cautioned that trust-building in the region remained incomplete, citing unresolved cases from last year's protests, seizure of personal devices and action against institutions linked to the movement.

In an interview with PTI on Saturday following the latest round of discussions with a

Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) sub-committee, Wangchuk said he noted a shift in his outlook after Thursday's meeting but remains cautious.

“This meeting has made some difference... Otherwise, I was very disappointed,” Wangchuk said, reflecting on his earlier experience of being detained this year.

He mentioned that the release order referred to creating “an environment of trust” and moving towards “meaningful and constructive dialogue.” However, he alleged that the reality on the

Rahul trying to create anarchy to topple Modi Govt, says BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Sunday accused Congress leader Rahul Gandhi of conspiring to destabilise the Narendra Modi Government by “creating anarchy” in the country, alleging that he was acting at the behest of foreign forces.

Several BJP leaders, including Union minister Piyush Goyal, claimed that Gandhi's “plan” was exposed after the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha reportedly said at a meeting of the advisory council of the Congress' Minority Department on Tuesday that the Modi government will fall within a year.

In a post on X in Hindi, Goyal said Gandhi's statement pointed to a “massive conspiracy” involving the Congress, several opposition parties, and what he described as a “toolkit gang”, which he alleged harboured dreams of destabilising



India. “This is no ordinary statement. Rather, it constitutes a grave conspiracy aimed at spreading anarchy in the country,” the senior BJP leader said, sharing a media report which claimed that Gandhi had said at the party meeting that the Modi government would fall within a year.

Goyal alleged that Gandhi and his “associates” were attempting to “incite violence” across the country after realising that the Congress could not defeat the BJP in a direct electoral contest or dislodge the Modi government, as people held the prime minister in high regard. “Their hatred against India runs so deep that they simply cannot bear to witness anything positive happening in the country,” he charged.

“The people of this country are discerning. They fully understand the true nature of Rahul Gandhi, the opposition, and the toolkit gang that is working against the national interest. Time and again, the people have responded strongly to these elements. The INDI Alliance's conspiracy to set India on fire will never succeed,” Goyal added.

BJP Rajya Sabha MP Sudhanshu Trivedi alleged that Gandhi's remarks reflected not just “political desperation” but also a public display of a “dangerous mindset aimed at destabilising India”.

“Whenever India has strengthened its position on the global stage, its economy has reached new heights and the world has acknowledged Prime Minister Modi's leadership, anti-India international forces have launched campaigns to defame the country and the Congress has lent them support,” the BJP national spokesperson said.

Pune school principal shared NEET-related questions, content for money: CBI to court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

Manisha Sanjay Havaladar, principal of a Pune school arrested in connection with the NEET-UG paper leak case, allegedly shared examination-related questions and content with a few students for money, the CBI told a court here, sources said on Sunday. The federal agency made the submission while seeking her transit remand, they said.

The Central Bureau of Intelligence (CBI) arrested Havaladar on Friday, calling her another source of the alleged paper leak. Havaladar, the principal of Seth Hiralal Saraf Prashala, worked as an empanelled translator for Physics for NEET UG-2026.

Following her arrest, she was produced before a court in Pune and is currently in transit remand. She is likely to be produced in a court in Delhi on Monday. The CBI informed the Pune court that its investiga-



tion into the case had revealed that Havaladar, in collusion with botany teacher Manisha Mandhare, now in custody, allegedly shared NEET-related questions and content with a few students in exchange for monetary benefits.

Sources said the CBI told the court that handwritten notes containing NEET-related questions were prepared and retained by Havaladar during her NTA (National Testing Agency) assignment.

The confidential material was allegedly used to convey examination-related content to some students before the NEET UG-2026 exam through WhatsApp and printouts.

Sources said Havaladar admitted to sharing Physics questions from NEET UG-2026, which she had translated or reverse-translated, with one student and with Manisha Mandhare, a botany lecturer from Modern College of Arts and Science in Pune. The probe found that Havaladar allegedly received ₹20,000 from one student and ₹25,000 from another person, CBI told the court, according to the sources.

Massive rally at Red Fort demands de-listing of converted tribals from ST category

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lakhs of members from various tribal communities from across the nation gathered at Delhi's Red Fort grounds on Sunday and called for the de-listing of converted tribals from the Scheduled Tribe category.

The 'Janajati Sanskritik Samagam', organised by the RSS affiliate Janajati Suraksha Manch and allied groups, was held in the backdrop of the 150th birth anniversary year of tribal icon Birsu Munda at Red Fort grounds.

The 'Janajati Sanskritik Samagam', organised by the RSS affiliate Janajati Suraksha Manch and allied groups, was held in the backdrop of the 150th birth anniversary year of tribal icon Birsu Munda at Red Fort grounds.

“This cultural programme is aimed at giving a major push to our long-pending demand for de-listing converted tribals from the Scheduled Tribe category. This issue goes back to the time of tribal leader Kartik Oraon ji, who raised it before the then prime minister Indira Gandhi in the late 1960s,” Maalaya Jigdung



People gather during the Janjati Sanskritik Samagam, marking the 150th birth anniversary celebrations of tribal icon Birsu Munda at Red Fort in New Delhi on Sunday

of the Janjati Suraksha Manch, Assam prant, said. Jigdung asserted that the mobilisation will help build wider national support for a constitutional amendment under Article 342.

Organisers claimed that nearly 1.5 lakh people from over 500 tribal communities across the country participated in the event.

“This has been one of our oldest demands and the core objective behind the formation of the Janjati Suraksha Manch. Through this programme, we have showcased tribal cultural identity while also strengthening our movement for de-listing,” Jigdung said.

The event began with cultural processions from five locations in the national capital — Rajghat Chowk, Ramlila Maidan, Ajmeri Gate Chowk, Qudsia Bagh near Kashmiri Gate and Shyamgiri Temple near Shastri Park Bus Depot. The rallies, covering around 2.5 to 3.5 kilometres, converged at the Red Fort grounds.

Participants dressed in traditional attire carried tribal flags, beat drums and performed folk dances as they marched through Delhi's streets.

Groups from Assam, Tripura, Bihar, Jharkhand, Odisha, Andaman and Nicobar and several other states took part in the event, which organisers described as the “largest tribal cultural mobilisation of its kind”.

Kartik Oraon, a prominent tribal leader from Bihar and former Congress MP, had submitted memoranda signed by hundreds of MPs in 1967 and 1970 seeking the removal of Scheduled Tribe benefits for tribals who had converted to Christianity or Islam.



ground did not reflect these assurances. “Nothing was happening on the ground. People were getting divided

pening, and meaningful dialogue seemed unlikely,” he said. “Last week was very negative. There was conflict everywhere.

I thought Ladakh would become another Manipur; it was heading in that direction,” he said. He said the latest engagement with the Centre has brought some relief. “Both sides have taken a step,” he said, referring to the meeting with the Home Ministry sub-committee. Wangchuk stated that optimism would depend on whether the government followed through with concrete

measures in the coming weeks. The activist highlighted several unresolved issues that continue to undermine confidence, including the ongoing seizure of his mobile phone, which was confiscated during protests about eight months ago.

“My mobile phone was taken when I was jailed. It has been more than two months since I was released, and I still do not have it back,” he said. He expressed the impact of this situation, saying, “Without it, I cannot book an Ola, an Uber, or even a plane ticket. (PTI)

NEET PAPER LEAK ISSUE

Congress will not rest till Pradhan resigns: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said his party will not rest until Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigns and a foolproof system is put in place to prevent paper leaks like in NEET.

He shared a video of students protesting in Hyderabad, highlighting the NEET paper leak and demanding Pradhan's resignation. They also raised slogans against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Pradhan.

“When millions of youth are on the streets, the future of 22 lakh children is at stake and the PM remains silent, then the government is not focused on responding but is busy evading,” the Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha said.

“Until Dharmendra Pradhan resigns and a fool-



Nearly 5.49 lakh candidates appeared in civil services preliminary exam: UPSC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Nearly 5.49 lakh candidates appeared in the civil services preliminary examination held on Sunday, the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) said.

For the first time this year, the commission introduced real-time face authentication of candidates at examination venues to prevent impersonation and strengthen the integrity of the examination process. The indigenously developed system through the National e-Governance Division (NeGD) of the Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (MeitY) worked perfectly across all examination venues, the UPSC said in a statement.

This was possibly the largest real-time face-authentication conducted by the UPSC and its 100 per cent success is a major step forward in the integrity processes of the commission, it said. The UPSC conducted the civil services (prelimi-



nary) examination 2026, including the Indian Forest Service (preliminary) exam at 2,072 examination venues in 83 examination centres (cities) across the country.

Out of a total of 8,19,732 candidates who had applied for the examination, nearly 5.49 lakh candidates (around 67 per cent) appeared for the examination, as per the provisional data.

In the civil services (preliminary) examination 2025, out

President to confer 66 Padma awards today



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu will present 66 Padma awards at the first civil investiture ceremony for 2026 to be held in the Ganatantra Mandap of the Rashtrapati Bhavan on Monday.

During the ceremony to be attended by Vice President C P Radhakrishnan, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, among others, the President will confer two Padma Vibhushan, six Padma Bhushan and 58 Padma Shri awards. For the year 2026, the President has approved the conferment of 131 Padma awards including five Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan and 113 Padma Shri awards. The remaining Padma awardees will be conferred in the second round of the ceremony to be held later, sources said. The awards are announced on the occasion of the Republic Day every year.

The coveted civilian honours are given in various fields — art, social work, public affairs, science and engineering, trade and indus-

try, medicine, literature and education, sports, civil service, etc.

Padma Vibhushan is awarded for exceptional and distinguished service while Padma Bhushan for distinguished service of high order and Padma Shri for distinguished service in any field.

Continuing with the principle of celebrating ordinary Indians making extraordinary contributions, this year's Padma awards include a wide spectrum of 45 unsung heroes from across the length and breadth of India, the sources said.

Each has overcome tremendous personal hardships and tragedies to not just excel in their chosen fields, but go further on to serve society at large, they said. These include individuals from marginalised and Dalit communities, primitive tribes and those from remote and difficult terrains, they added. These are people who have dedicated their entire lifetimes in service of the disabled, women, children, Dalits and tribals working to promote healthcare, education, livelihood, sanitation, sustainability, etc.



States Focus



J&K CM CONDOLES DEATH OF MP ABDUL RASHID'S FATHER

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah visited the residence of Member of Parliament Abdul Rashid Sheikh and Langate MLA Khurshed Ahmed Sheikh on Sunday to offer condolences on the demise of their father, Khizar Mohammad Sheikh. Khizar Sheikh, 85, died at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences, New Delhi, last week, where he had been undergoing treatment. The chief minister spent time with the bereaved family and expressed deep sorrow over the loss. An official spokesperson said Abdullah was accompanied by Minister Javid Ahmed Dar, Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) Choudhary Mohammad Ramzaan, several legislators and other dignitaries.



HEAVY RAINS, STRONG WINDS LASH PARTS OF KERALA

As heavy rains and strong winds lashed parts of Kerala, the IMD on Sunday issued an orange alert in one district of the state and a yellow alert in 11 others. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued an orange alert in Ernakulam district for the day. It issued a yellow alert in 11 districts of the state, except Palakkad and Wayanad. An orange alert means very heavy rain of 11 cm to 20 cm, while a yellow alert means heavy rainfall between 6 cm and 11 cm. The strong winds and rains caused damage to property and vehicles in some parts of the state.

Karnataka: 10 drown in Tatte Hakkalu river

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Karwar (Karnataka)

At least 10 members of a family, including seven women, drowned, while two others were reported missing after a group attempting to collect freshwater mussels was swept away by strong currents in the Tatte Hakkalu river in Uttara Kannada district, police sources said on Sunday.

Expressing grief, President Droupadi Murmu said the incident was "very distressing". "I extend my deepest condolences to those who lost their loved ones. I pray for speedy recovery of the injured," she said on X.

In a post on X, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he was deeply pained to hear about the mishap in Karwar district.

"My condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. May the injured recover at the earliest," he said.

An ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh from the PMNRF would be given to the next of kin of each deceased. The injured would be given ₹50,000, he said.

Mourning the tragedy, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah announced a solatium of ₹5 lakh to the next of kin of each victim.

According to police sources, around 14 people from Shirali village had entered the river to collect mussels, a seasonal activity practised by local communities along riverbanks and coastal regions.

During the process, they allegedly moved deeper into the river without accurately assessing the water level.



People gather after eight members of a family, including seven women, drowned while two others were reported missing at Karwar in Uttara Kannada district, Karnataka

PTI

When the water flow suddenly increased, one or two persons were swept away."

Several others then jumped into the river in an attempt to rescue those struggling in the water, leading to more people being

caught in the strong current. Police sources said ten bodies had been recovered so far.

Among the deceased, eight people have been identified as Umesh Manjunath Naik (40), Laxmi Mahadev Naik (42), Laxmi Jattappa Naik (30),

Laxmi Appanna Naik (60), Laxmi Shivaram Naik (49), Jyoti Mastamma Naik (34), Malati Naik (38) and Mastamma Naik (60).

The two people who were rescued are Nagaratna and Mahadevi, who have been admitted to the hospital.

Rescue personnel, police teams and local residents were continuing intensive search operations in the river.

The deceased were stated to be natives of Shirali in Bhatkal taluk.

The sources said the incident occurred after the river current intensified amid rains in the region, sweeping away multiple persons who had ventured into deeper sections of the waterbody while collecting mussels.

Collecting freshwater mussels is a livelihood activ-

ity for some sections of people, similar to fishing. Many of those involved were experienced in the work and had reportedly undertaken such activities earlier as well, sources said.

Authorities were yet to ascertain how many among the victims knew swimming and the exact sequence of events leading to the tragedy, police sources added.

In a post on X, Siddaramaiah said he was deeply distressed to learn about the "extremely tragic and painful incident" and prayed for peace to the departed souls.

On humanitarian grounds, the state government will provide compensation of Rs five lakh each to the families of those who died in this tragedy, he said.

Development means improved living standards of people: Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kochi

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Sunday said that development does not mean construction of big buildings, rather it envisages improving the living standards of the people and outlined a slew of plans to modernise and transform the port city, Ernakulam district and the state.

Speaking at an event organised to felicitate the CM, ministers and MLAs from Ernakulam district, Satheesan said the UDF plans for the state primarily include improving the economic situation of Kerala and the living standards of the people.

He said that improving the economic situation of the state was a challenge and so was taking charge of the Finance Department.

"If we can improve our economic situation, then the next thing to be done is equitable distribution of wealth. We need to examine what all we can do to improve the living standards of the people."

"Development is part of it. But it does not mean acquiring land and constructing huge buildings. It



comes when there is a visible improvement in the living standards of the people," he contended.

He said that the UDF was the first opposition in the country which not only criticised the ruling government but also carried out studies on what can be done in the areas in which the administration had failed. Satheesan said he will be presenting the first budget of the new government in the assembly on June 19, and it will contain numerous projects for all the sectors, including health, educa-

tion and basic infrastructure.

Without going into details, the CM said that the plans include turning the entire state into a seaport city, initiating in Kerala the highest number of aviation projects in Asia and transforming Kochi city into a model for the country by making it one of the most modern cities.

He said that Kochi should grow beyond its current limits to become a 'twin city' with administrative offices located away from its heart.

Rahul's remarks predicting NDA Govt fall mere daydream: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nagpur

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Sunday dismissed Rahul Gandhi's claim that the NDA Government will collapse soon, likening the Congress leader's remarks to daydreaming and calling it mere imagination.

The BJP has alleged that

Gandhi, the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha, reportedly said at a meeting of the advisory council of the Congress's Minority Department on Tuesday that the Modi government will fall within a year.

Asked about Gandhi's statement predicting the government's fall in the coming months, Fadnavis said, "There used to be a popular televi-



sion serial called 'Mungerilal Ke Haseen Sapne' (daydreaming). His remark is nothing more than that."

The chief minister was speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the launch of the Godam Logistics Park in Nagpur. He said that the region's manufacturing sector stands to gain immensely from the state-of-the-art logistics park.

Ladakh LG Saxena launches ecological restoration project

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Leh/Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Sunday launched an ambitious ecological restoration project to reclaim nearly 800 acres of barren land near Spituk and transform it into a productive ecosystem through innovative freshwater recharge techniques. This was a major initiative launched by the LG aimed at reversing land degradation in the cold desert region of Ladakh.

Officials said that the pilot project has been undertaken on the directions of the LG Saxena after identify-



ing around 800 acres of land near Spituk village in Leh that has remained barren for centuries.

"The initiative seeks to utilise excess water from the recently restored

Igoo-Phey irrigation canal by diverting it across the degraded landscape through temporary channels and minor earthwork interventions using tractors and other machinery", they

said. Ladakh receives less than 100 mm of annual rainfall and is heavily dependent on glacial meltwater, they said. However, rapid runoff during early spring often leads to soil erosion, inadequate groundwater recharge and declining soil moisture, contributing to the expansion of arid and unproductive land.

According to officials, the project aims to alter the local ecosystem by allowing freshwater to spread and percolate into the soil, thereby replenishing depleted aquifers, restoring groundwater levels and triggering natural vegetation growth.

Chhattisgarh: Arms, explosives recovered in Kanker district

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanker

Security forces have recovered a cache of arms, explosives, and other Naxal-related materials during two separate operations along the Kanker-Narayanpur border in Chhattisgarh's Kanker district, police officials said on Sunday.

The Government had

earlier announced the successful eradication of decades-old Naxal insurgency in Chhattisgarh.

The operations were jointly carried out by personnel of the District Reserve Guard (DRG), district police, Border Security Force (BSF) and Bomb Disposal Squad (BDS) in sensitive forested and hilly areas, they said.

Police said the operations



were conducted under the supervision of Bastar Range Inspector General of Police Sundarraaj P., BSF and district police officials of Kanker and Narayanpur districts. On May 22, security personnel launched a search operation in the forest area between Pallahur and Japmarka villages, under the Koilibeda police station limits, along the Kanker-Narayanpur border.

DMK slams Shivakumar over Mekedatu dam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chennai

The DMK on Sunday lashed out at Karnataka Deputy Chief Minister DK Shivakumar over the Mekedatu dam issue, alleging he displayed "arrogant attitude" by claiming Tamil Nadu had no right to raise objection over the project on the River Cauvery.

As per the Supreme Court order, no construction activity could be done at Mekedatu without the prior per-



mission of the lower riparian states, senior DMK leader K N Nehru said.

The DMK principal secretary claimed Shivakumar has said that Tamil Nadu has no right to object to the dam "and this shows his arrogant attitude."

"Looks like he has made such remarks thinking that a weak coalition government is in place in Tamil Nadu. He has made these audacious remarks thinking there will be

no opposition since his Congress party is part of the government in the state," Nehru said in a statement.

"Shivakumar has said the Karnataka government is keen on constructing the dam. Our leader (DMK chief MK Stalin) will not hesitate to make any sacrifice to ensure Tamil Nadu's right in the Cauvery River," Nehru added. The issue has led to outrage in the Cauvery delta districts in Tamil Nadu, he said.

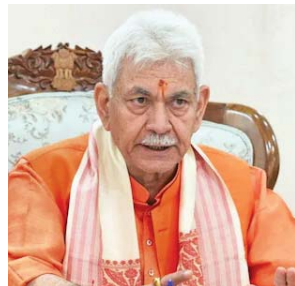
India trusts its youth to lead country to greater heights: J&K LG Sinha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Sunday said that India trusts its youth to lead the country to greater heights.

Addressing the 'Special National Integration Camp' organised by the National Cadet Corps (NCC) Directorate, Jammu Kashmir and Ladakh, the LG said, "India places its hope and confidence in its youth, trusting that the young generation will lead the nation to greater heights. NCC cadets must honour that trust by living the values of the NCC and spreading across communities."

During his interaction with NCC cadets from across the country, Sinha emphasised that this special camp is a living symbol of India's spirit,



where every cadet is not just witnessing history but actively shaping it.

Sinha said that for India, diversity is the greatest strength and for many centuries, our greatest strength lies in turning diversity into unity, weaving many cultures into one shared national spirit.

"The values of unity in diversity and the leadership qualities you have learned at this camp must be put to use in improving society. Equally

important is the seed of patriotism sown here must be carried forward with full responsibility and dedication to the youth in your states and cities," he said.

Observing that the youth of the NCC are both India's strength today and the builders of its tomorrow, the LG said the youth are inheriting a world of rapid change, which may unsettle many nations, but India's youth are full of confidence, equipped with skills to rise to meet these challenges with courage and capability.

Highlighting the remarkable creative energy and a strong readiness to move forward possessed by NCC cadets, Sinha said he wanted to get that energy channelled with a clear purpose so that they can stand firm against any future challenge.

Bengal: Districts asked to build holding centres for illegal foreigners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

West Bengal's BJP Government has moved to institutionalise its "detect, delete and deport" policy by directing all district administrations to set up "holding centres" for suspected illegal foreigners and foreign prisoners awaiting repatriation — a step that appeared to give administrative shape to one of the party's most potent political themes in the State.

The order, issued by the State Home and Hill Affairs Department's Foreigners' Branch on May 23, asked district magistrates to create the infrastructure required to house "apprehended foreign-

ers" and "released foreign prisoners" until deportation formalities are completed.

Though framed as a procedural exercise aligned with central guidelines, the directive comes days after Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari publicly rolled out a tougher anti-infiltration framework and declared that his Government had adopted a "detect, delete and deport" policy — a phrase long embedded in the BJP's Bengal vocabulary on infiltration and border politics.

The communication referred to an advisory of the Union Home Ministry in May last year laying down procedures for handling Bangladeshi nationals and

Rohingyas found staying illegally in India.

"In this connection, it is requested to take initiative/appropriate action for setting up of Holding Centres in the district for apprehended foreigners as well as for the released foreign prisoners awaiting deportation/repatriation," the order said.

Copies of the communication have been sent to the director general of police, police commissionerates, superintendents of police, and the Foreigners Regional Registration Office in Kolkata.

Officials said the proposed centres would function as temporary transit facilities for those detained on suspi-



West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari

PTI

cion of illegal stay and for foreign nationals whose deportation processes are underway.

Under central guidelines,

suspected illegal entrants can be kept in such facilities for up to 30 days while their nationality and documents are verified. District magis-

trates or officers of equivalent rank would take the final call on citizenship determination.

The framework also envisages the collection of biometric data, uploading of information to a central portal and eventual transfer of identified illegal immigrants to border authorities for repatriation.

A senior official said the move was intended to ensure district administrations remain "prepared and compliant" with existing procedures.

"The districts have been asked to create the necessary infrastructure so that such cases can be dealt with in a regulated manner till legal formalities are

completed," he said.

Yet, coming against the backdrop of the state's recent political transition, the order seemed to carry significance beyond its bureaucratic language.

Only days earlier, Adhikari announced that infiltrators detained by State police would be handed over directly to the BSF for deportation instead of being routed through prolonged legal processes.

At a meeting with senior BSF officers where land was handed over for fencing work in stretches along the Bangladesh border, the chief minister had declared that the state's anti-infiltration agenda had entered the

implementation phase.

He said those not covered under the Citizenship (Amendment) Act would be treated as illegal entrants.

"Those who are outside the purview of the CAA are illegal entrants and will be arrested by the state police and handed over to the BSF," Adhikari had said.

The BSF, according to the mechanism, would coordinate with Border Guards Bangladesh for deportation.

Though Adhikari did not specifically cite the legal framework, officials indicated the mechanism appeared linked to the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025, enacted by Parliament last year.



SECURITY FORCES HUNT GROUP OF FOREIGN TERRORISTS IN J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jammu

Multiple teams of security forces intensified a hot chase on Sunday to hunt down a group of foreign terrorists inside the forest belt of Dorimal-Gambhir Moghla in the frontier district of Rajouri.

Additional troops were also rushed to the spot to plug the gaps.

The initial contact was established with the terrorists on Saturday during the intelligence-based cordon and search operations in the area.

According to official sources, the security forces strengthened the cordon by deploying additional troops in the area. Senior army officers stationed in the division headquarters were supervising the anti-terror operations.

According to preliminary reports, the movement of two to three terrorists was suspected in the area. Teams belonging to the special operations group of the Jammu and Kashmir police and central paramilitary forces are also maintaining a tight vigil in the outer cordon to prevent the terrorists from escaping the tight cordon.

Assam to set up counter-radicalisation cell: Himanta

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday said his Government will set up a counter-radicalisation cell to "protect vulnerable youth from extremist influence". He asserted that Assam will "give it back firmly" to anyone trying to mislead the youth of the State.

"We will not allow any group or individual to mislead our youth and ruin their future by radicalising them. Assam will give it back firmly," Sarma said in a post on X. "A counter-radicalisation cell will be established to protect vulnerable youth from extremist influence," the chief minister said. Sarma, however, did not elaborate on the proposed cell.



Sabarimala gold loss: No one who stole from God will be spared, says K Muraleedharan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Devaswoms Minister K Muraleedharan on Sunday said that no one involved in the Sabarimala gold loss case would be spared irrespective of their party leanings.

Muraleedharan said that he was waiting for the report of the Special Investigation Team (SIT) and, accordingly, further action would be taken.

"No one who steals from

God will be spared. Whosoever they are, and whichever party they belong to, strong action will be taken against them. None of the culprits will be protected," the minister asserted.

Speaking to reporters here, Muraleedharan, who is also in charge of the health department, further said that there was no need to be concerned about the Ebola outbreaks in other parts of the world, as no cases have been reported in India, and stringent screen-

ing systems have been set up at airports and seaports to detect early symptoms among those arriving from abroad. He said that instructions have also been issued to set up such systems in major railway stations in Kerala, as some people who came from abroad and landed in other states might travel to the southern state by train.

The minister said that isolation wards have been set up in Government medical colleges

Thiruvananthapuram, Kochi, Kozhikode and Kannur and urged those coming from abroad to immediately contact health professionals on witnessing initial symptoms like fever, cough or diarrhoea with blood.

Muraleedharan said that according to health experts, during the first two days of Ebola infection there will only be mild symptoms, which people tend to ignore, but by day 4, they increase in severity, and death occurs by day 12.

Congress Govt betrayed people of Karnataka, alleges Nitin Nabin

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Sunday targeted the Congress Government in Karnataka, alleging that the administration had "betrayed" the people of the State and diverted its focus away from development and welfare activities over the past three years.

Speaking during his two-day visit to Karnataka, Nabin said the ruling Congress in the state was plagued by internal conflicts and accused its leaders of "using power for personal interests" rather than governance.

"The Karnataka Government has deceived the people here over the past three years, betrayed the trust of the people, and because of their internal conflicts, public welfare works have taken a back seat," he said.

He indirectly referred to the 'power tussle' between Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and his deputy DK Shivakumar.

Claiming that the state Government was disconnected from public concerns, Nabin said, "The Government here has nothing to do with the interests of the people. The leaders running this Government are using the Government and power merely as instruments for themselves."

He alleged that developmental and welfare programmes in Karnataka had suffered due to the Congress Government's priorities. "The Government's focus has been completely diverted from development schemes



Nitin Nabin during a meeting with party leaders, MPs and MLAs at the party office in Bengaluru on Sunday

PTI

that should have been implemented for the people of this state and the welfare activities that should have been carried out," he said.

Nabin also accused the Congress of "financially exploiting" Karnataka for the benefit of its national leadership.

"Congress is using Karnataka as an ATM to decorate and sustain its court in Delhi," he alleged.

Referring to his visit, the BJP leader said district-level training camps of the party were being held across the country and added that he had reviewed organisational activities in Karnataka during his tour.

"I am on a two-day visit to Karnataka. Training camps are currently being conducted for districts across our country. I got the opportunity to participate in that, and at the same time, I also got the opportunity to observe how the party's active organisational activities are continuously moving forward in Karnataka," he said.

Woman held in Dehradun businessman murder case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dehradun

The Dehradun Police has arrested a woman, carrying a reward of Rs 25,000, from Saharanpur in connection with the murder of a local businessman last year, officials said on Sunday.

The arrested accused has been identified as Humera alias Zoya, a resident of UP's Muzaffarnagar.

Zoya's arrest came days after co-accused, Rajan alias Jacky, a sharpshooter, was held from Muzaffarnagar on May 19.

Both Zoya and Rajan had accepted a contract to kill Ajay Bhateja (54) at the behest of his stepbrother Amit, over a property dispute, police said.

Ajay was found dead at his Krishna Vihar residence on May 26, last year. His body lay on the floor with a bleeding nose, while a sheet hung from the ceiling fan to stage a suicide.

Following a complaint from Ajay's cousin Jatinder Kumar, police filed an FIR under Section 103 (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Police used mobile surveillance, CCTV footage, and informants to track Rajan and Zoya.

During questioning, Rajan had confessed to smothering

Ajay with a pillow on May 25, police said.

Amit wanted a share in Ajay's multiple properties located across Dehradun and Mussoorie, which triggered a bitter dispute between the stepbrothers.

Amit lured Rajan into the plot by promising him a half share in Ajay's property in Jakhna, Dehradun. Rajan subsequently roped in Zoya to execute the murder plan, SSP Pramendra Singh Dobhal said.

On the night of the incident, Rajan, Zoya, Amit, and another friend, Neeraj, visited Ajay's residence. While the others left the house later that night, Zoya stayed behind with the victim.

Rajan returned to the house around 1 am and made Ajay drink alcohol. The accused then used a pillow to smother Ajay to death, the SSP said.

During questioning, Rajan said he attempted to hang the body from the ceiling fan to fake a suicide, but fled in a hurry with Amit and Neeraj, who were waiting outside in a car.

Neeraj had no prior knowledge of the murder conspiracy, the SSP said.

The main conspirator, Amit Bhateja, remains at large. Teams are conducting raids to arrest him, they added.

CEC Gyanesh Kumar reviews SIR preparations in Uttarakhand

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dehradun

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar reviewed the preparations for the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls at a high-level meeting here on Sunday.

The review meeting took place at the State Guest House in Bijapur on the second day of the CEC's visit to Uttarakhand. Kumar said the main objective of the SIR is to refine the voters' list by identifying absent,



shifted, deceased, duplicate and foreign voters. The CEC appealed to all voters to cooperate with Booth Level Officers (BLOs) and provide their latest passport-size photographs during the upcoming revision.

Chief Electoral Officer BVR C Purushottam delivered a detailed presentation during the meeting.

He informed the chief election commissioner that officials completed 89 per cent of the mapping during the pre-SIR phase in the state. The state completed preparations for

printing the enumeration forms, Purushottam added.

The first phase of training for District Election Officers (DEOs), Deputy DEOs, and Electoral Registration Officers (EROs) is complete. Training for BLOs and other field staff is currently underway across the state.

Officials told the CEC that the state is running extensive voter awareness campaigns through various media for the special intensive revision.

Mamata says INDIA bloc likely to meet in early June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday said members of the INDIA bloc were likely to meet in the first week of June to discuss a joint strategy, while asserting that the opposition camp was prepared for a prolonged political battle.

"We are ready to fight, and we will not give up till the end," Banerjee said in a Facebook Live address.

Using the platform to launch a fresh attack on the BJP, the TMC supremo



alleged large-scale electoral manipulation and claimed the Trinamool Congress's popular mandate had been overturned in around 150 assembly constituencies. "Winning seats were

turned into losing seats and losing ones into winning seats," she alleged while claiming that otherwise the TMC would have secured between 220 and 230 seats. Rejecting the allegations,

senior BJP leader Keya Ghosh accused Banerjee of refusing to accept the electoral verdict and attempting to explain away the defeat through conspiracy theories.

Ghosh questioned why the TMC chief was raising concerns over the electoral process now when her party accepted as legitimate the elections it won in 2011, 2016 and 2021.

"She is unable to face defeat and is not ready to accept it. If the elections of 2011, 2016 and 2021 were fair, why are you suddenly raising questions now? By floating these conspiracy

theories, she is disregarding the Constitution. For her victory means, booth jamming, violence and assault on political opponents," Ghosh said.

The TMC chairperson reiterated allegations of irregularities in voter rolls and election procedures, claiming that the electoral process had been compromised.

"Nearly 60 lakh names were deleted initially (through the SIR process). Though many were restored later, we have information suggesting manipulation and irregularities at different stages," she alleged.

Bihar Chamber of Commerce and Industries can help Govt maximise investment in State: CM Choudhary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Sunday said the Bihar Chamber of Commerce and Industries can play a crucial role in realising the state Government's aim of achieving industrial growth and attracting maximum investment.

At the inauguration of a programme marking the centenary celebrations of the Bihar Chamber of

Commerce and Industries (BCCI), he said the state will transition from "progress to prosperity" with the cooperation of the business community and promised "all possible facilities" to investors.

"The state Government formulated the Bihar Industrial Investment Promotion Package-2025 to attract private investment and boost industrial development. The Government wants maximum investment and industrial growth



in Bihar, and the BCCI has an important role in this effort," he said.

The chief minister lamented that the expected levels of investment have

not come to Bihar despite the state having formulated "one of India's top industrial policies."

"Any crime committed in the state is being acted upon within 24 hours on a priority basis. No one can take the law into their own hands in Bihar. District magistrates and superintendents of police would hold meetings with businesspersons every three months to address security concerns and other problems," Choudhary said.

"Look, because of SIR, a lot of harm is happening in this country. Poor people still do not fully understand this process. In some states, they are removing 50 lakh, 60 lakh, even 90 lakh names like this," Shivakumar, who is Congress Karnataka unit president, said.

Noting that the issue transcended party lines, Shivakumar said, "Whether they are Congress Party supporters or BJP supporters, we do not care -- all poor voters must individually submit applications for this. If they do not submit applications, they will lose their voting rights."

He warned that losing voting rights could have wider implications for welfare entitlements.





Editor's
TAKE

Addressing India's jobs crisis

The employment question is not merely economic – it is deeply linked to dignity and aspiration of the youth and affects national confidence

Any nation that aspires to be super power must be backed by its youth that is meaningfully employed and has a positive mindset. Indeed, India is one of the youngest nation of the world has a sizable youthful energy. But if it is not engaged in constructive work there is a high chance of it going wayward. In keeping with his commitment to provide jobs Prime Minister Narendra Modi presided over the 19th edition of the Rozgar Mela, distributing appointment letters to over 51,000 freshly recruited government employees across 47 locations nationwide. The ceremony was warm. The intent, no doubt, is genuine. But the arithmetic is brutal. India adds roughly a million young people to its workforce every single month. Fifty-one thousand government posts, distributed once every few months, is a gesture – not a solution. Youth unemployment in India stood at 15.2 per cent as of March 2026, up from lows of 13.8 per cent just a year earlier, with young women faring far worse at nearly 18 per cent. The Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy(CMIE) an independent body, has consistently placed unemployment between 7-8 per cent – more than double the government's own survey figures – reflecting a chasm between how joblessness is measured and how it is experienced. Behind every statistic is a graduate sending out hundreds of applications, a young person cycling between gig stints, a family waiting on one steady income that never seems to arrive. Over 30 lakh vacancies remain unfilled in central government departments alone – even as Rozgar Melas distribute letters in the tens of thousands. The PM's original 2014 promise of two crore jobs a year now reads as a stark reminder of the distance between ambition and delivery. None of this is to say the Rozgar Mela is without value. For the 51,000 individuals who received their letters on Friday, this is life-changing. A government job in India remains a rare, coveted thing – stable, pensioned, insulated from the chaos of informal work that employs the vast majority of Indians. Every vacancy filled is a family's circumstances altered. That matters.

But the deeper crisis is structural, and ceremonial hiring drives cannot fix it. India's private sector – particularly manufacturing – has failed to absorb the demographic dividend at scale. The Production Linked Incentive scheme holds promise, and PM Modi's recent agreements with the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway, and Italy in semiconductors, AI, and advanced manufacturing could, over time, seed high-quality employment. The keyword is time. Youth cannot wait a decade. The way forward demands three urgent shifts. First, a serious and transparent accounting of vacancies – not as political ammunition, but as a national obligation. If 30 lakh posts are empty in central government, they must be filled. Second, invest massively in quality skilling under PMKVY and allied programmes so that the millions outside government employment can compete in formal private sector jobs. Third, make it genuinely easier for small and medium enterprises to hire, expand, and formalise – because that is where the bulk of India's employment must ultimately come from.

IPL 2026: Time to Rebalance the Game

The IPL's strength lies in this very ability to reinvent attention around cricket. The task ahead, therefore, is to ensure that spectacle does not overpower skill, entertainment does not erase emotion, and commercial success nurtures cricket



CHAITANYA K PRASAD

Since its inception, every edition of IPL has brought a new wave of enthusiasm and expectation among cricket followers, passionate fans and key stakeholders. Each IPL season has brought with it a new kind of aggression, overdrive and unfiltered innovation in how cricket is played, packaged and understood in this new format.

Nonetheless, in 2026, something new seems to be missing in the IPL season. The flavour and variety are still there, yet the contrasts and the winning matrix seem to be missing in the overall IPL architecture. The general feeling among enthusiasts is that a kind of 'cricket fatigue' has entered the IPL domain, and the perception is that the IPL needs to detox to fully energise the minds and hearts of sports lovers once again.

Cricket over the years has reconfigured itself, keeping in mind the changing taste of audiences. A gentleman's game, as it was popularly called in the yesteryears, has now become part of the "Masala Cricket" bandwagon. Has the game reached a litmus testing point in the 2026 edition?

There is no doubt that the emotional connect of the format is still wired to the audiences. The outreach tools, sporting traits, ideas and entertainment touchpoints still dominate the ecosystem. Nonetheless, there is growing scepticism around IPL as a brand and an idea, with concerns that it may be overstretched, over-expanded or even over-optimised.

The fear among followers of the game is that the design quotient, or the novel experiment of the IPL format, is beginning to dry up for want of fresh ideas, over-monetisation and over-extension of cricket as a game vis-à-vis entertainment, skills and unpredictability.

The thrill factor of IPL, which acted as a catalyst in previous editions, is waning. The craze and idol worship of foreign players has perhaps outlived its utility. What was unique in the past is now the new normal. Consistency in viewing the IPL matches still commands TV advertisement, but audience attention has been divided into several segments. There is what we may call 'viewing' or 'audience burnout'. The uproar and support for franchise teams has also slid, at times due to the cricketing crossroads syndrome between the old and new generation. The connect of audiences with both the old and the new would need to be worked out for future editions.

A point to ponder for all cricket lovers: has IPL taken the wind out of the sails? This year's edition has perhaps challenged the cricket legacy, professionalism and nitty-gritties associated with the game. Twenty overs have seen skyrocketing scores, and sixes are being hit almost as casual-



THE SANCTITY ASSOCIATED WITH THE GAME HAS BEEN SHAKEN. THE TWENTY-OVER BLITZ, WITH NEW TWISTS AND TURNS, HAS OVERRUN THE 22-YARD PHILOSOPHY. THERE IS A NEW FANTASY FRONTIER BEING UNVEILED IN EVERY MATCH

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balance would need to be laid out for building perception, visibility and advertising. Extreme commercialisation has taken IPL to a point where its identity risks being lost in the attention-span ecosystem. While the advertising kitty has improved and more corporates have joined the bandwagon, the problem today for Brand IPL and brand cricket is the overcrowding of the cricketing ecosystem. The challenge still remains to ensure the legacy, freshness and continuity of cricket as a sport. IPL must and should remain the nursery and talent pool for future cricketing generations. Overexposed cricket is not the solution to this idea. A reworked social media ecosystem for IPL needs to be re-engineered through fresh minds, fresh thought and new parameters and verticals of cricketing content consumption, ideas and patterns.

"Cricket extortion" should not become the IPL mantra. The sport must not be sacrificed at the altar of the money mantra, nor become a victim of showbiz, charisma, 24x7 digital engagement and consistent spectacle without sporting depth.

Despite these concerns, it would be unfair to dismiss the IPL's larger contribution to Indian and global cricket. The league has transformed the cricketing economy, created a powerful platform for young domestic talent, strengthened India's sporting brand and given players exposure to pressure, scale and international competition at a very early stage. It has also expanded cricket's cultural vocabulary by taking the game beyond stadiums into homes, digital platforms, fan communities and everyday conversations. The IPL's strength lies in this very ability to reinvent attention around cricket.

The task ahead, therefore, is not to dilute the IPL, but to refine it, to ensure that spectacle does not overpower skill, entertainment does not erase emotion, and commercial success continues to serve the deeper purpose of nurturing cricket.

The 2026 IPL edition has to be a learning curve for the IPL strategists. While the brand identity remains unsurpassed, hugely massive and emotionally connected, there are a few takeaways for future editions.

The IPL does not need to lose its colour, glamour or energy; that has always been part of its appeal. What it needs now is a thoughtful recalibration that protects the soul of cricket while embracing the possibilities of a modern sporting spectacle. If future editions can restore the balance between bat and ball, give greater meaning to team legacies, create fresher fan narratives and continue to nurture young Indian talent, the league can enter an even stronger phase of its journey. The IPL still has the scale, imagination and emotional pull to renew itself. With the right course correction, it can remain not just cricket's biggest entertainment product, but also its most exciting nursery of talent, innovation and hope for the next generation.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

Healing requires more than medicine



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

I was recently at a well-known hospital for a follow-up consultation when I noticed an elderly couple standing hesitantly near the billing counters, visibly uncertain about the procedure they were expected to follow. What struck me was the absence of anyone attentive enough to recognise their discomfort and assist them. My wife, standing some distance away, sensed their unease and quietly walked forward to help. A little later, I saw the same couple again at the coordinator's desk, trying to make sense of a junior doctor's instructions. They returned a few minutes later, still uncertain about the directions. The doctor repeated the explanation politely, though a trace of irritation had now entered his voice. Nearby, another young doctor was explaining something to a rustic-looking patient with far less patience and sensitivity.

A few days later, in another reputed hospital, I witnessed a similar moment of confusion. An elderly man and his son were standing in a long queue. The son had already completed the appointment and payment online. They need not have spent more time in the queue after waiting there so long already. I explained the process to them and directed them towards the consultation area.

Another experience stayed with me even more strongly. A hospital had recently opened a geriatric department, and impressed by the idea, I took my father there for consultation. A young doctor listened to him for a few minutes before interrupting midway and writing out a prescription without hearing the complete medical history. We had hoped he would guide us towards appropriate care. Yet, despite having no waiting patients outside, he appeared impatient to engage further.

My grey-haired cardiologist consistently gives patients the time required to understand complex medical terms and treatment options. My younger ophthalmologist embodies genuine care. She greets patients warmly, explains things calmly, and apologises personally for delays. Both these compassionate doctors work within the same hospital systems where I had witnessed impatience and indifference. The issue lies somewhere deeper in the gradual erosion of certain human abilities that are becoming increasingly critical in highly system-

driven environments. We observe a diminishing presence of patience, attentiveness, and empathy. Modern systems have become faster, more technologically efficient, and administratively streamlined, but human beings do not always move at the same speed as systems. Healthcare and other institutional spaces are increasingly transactional environments where vulnerability is handled procedurally rather than understood empathetically. The ability to listen patiently and respond with sensitivity is cultivated slowly over time. It is perhaps here that literature and the arts assume deeper relevance than we often acknowledge. Such engagement allows individuals to encounter lives beyond their own. And yet, I increasingly encounter resistance even to such ideas. Parents often oppose such initiatives related to literature and the arts in favour of narrow utilitarian pursuits. In hospitals, senior administrators sometimes ask how literature can possibly be connected to medical intervention. The issue is not whether literature cures disease, but whether societies still recognise the importance of cultivating human beings capable of understanding suffering with patience, dignity, and care. Perhaps this is where institutions must rediscover their human side.

The Pioneer
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Sanjay Chandra, founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, and strategy consultant.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Balance US ties with strategic autonomy

The recent discussions between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Marco Rubio underline the growing importance of India-US ties in an increasingly uncertain geopolitical environment. Cooperation in defence, advanced technologies, trade and Indo-Pacific security offers India significant opportunities for economic growth, technological advancement and stronger global influence. Washington's continued outreach also reflects India's rising strategic importance in balancing China's assertiveness in the region. However, history reminds us that international relations are driven by national interests rather than permanent alliances. While the United States has often supported India on key issues, it has also imposed sanctions and strategic pressure whenever its priorities shifted. Therefore, India must approach this partnership with clarity and caution. India's greatest strength lies in preserving its strategic autonomy. Closer engagement with the US should not translate into overdependence. Maintaining balanced ties with Russia, Europe and other major powers remains essential for safeguarding India's long-term interests. A multi-aligned foreign policy allows India to maximise opportunities while retaining diplomatic flexibility in a rapidly changing global order.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

Satire often signals deeper public discontent

The viral "Cockroach Janata Party" phenomenon on social media may appear humorous on the surface, but it reflects a far deeper undercurrent of frustration among younger citizens. In a world marked by economic uncertainty, unemployment, technological disruption and declining trust in institutions, such digital satire has become an outlet for accumulated anxiety and alienation. History repeatedly shows that humour is not merely entertainment; it is often society's earliest warning signal. The Arab Spring, the French Revolution and even Sri Lanka's recent crisis emerged from prolonged public resentment that authorities failed to recognise in time. What begins as mockery can gradually evolve into political mobilisation when citizens feel unheard and excluded. In today's digital age, public sentiment spreads at unprecedented speed. Governments and institutions would therefore be mistaken to dismiss online satire as trivial meme culture. Beneath the jokes lies a widening trust deficit, particularly among younger generations.

Wise leadership should not fear criticism expressed through humour but instead treat it as valuable feedback. Satire frequently reveals concerns that official reports and political speeches fail to capture.

R. NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Need to protect Tamil Nadu's core ideals

Recent political developments in Tamil Nadu have raised concerns among many who strongly identify with the state's long-standing Dravidian ideals of social justice, self-respect, women's empowerment and communal harmony.

Internal divisions within the AIADMK and changing political alliances have created uncertainty about the future direction of Dravidian politics at a time when many fear growing attempts to polarise society along religious lines. For decades, both the DMK and the AIADMK have drawn strength from the broader ideological foundation laid by Periyar E.V. Ramasamy.

Though political rivalry has shaped Tamil Nadu's electoral landscape, the core principles of social equality and rationalism have remained central to public life. Many citizens now worry that continued fragmentation may weaken these shared ideals.

In this context, leaders of both parties should place ideological continuity above political rivalry and explore ways to strengthen the Dravidian movement collectively. Constructive dialogue and cooperation could help preserve the social and political values that have long distinguished Tamil Nadu. Safeguarding these principles is more important than short-term political calculations.

MANAPADIAN JOSON | CHENNAI

INDIA ISSUES TRAVEL ADVISORY AMID GROWING EBOLA OUTBREAK

India's advisory cautioning citizens against non-essential travel to the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Uganda and South Sudan reflects the seriousness of the latest Ebola outbreak linked to the Bundibugyo strain. With the World Health Organisation declaring the situation a Public Health Emergency of International Concern, heightened vigilance is both timely and necessary. The absence of an approved vaccine or specific treatment for this strain makes the outbreak particularly alarming, especially for countries with strong international mobility links. The government's decision to intensify surveillance at airports and advise Indians in affected regions to strictly follow health

protocols demonstrates prudent public health preparedness. In an interconnected world, infectious diseases can spread rapidly across borders, making early caution far more effective than delayed response.

India's healthcare authorities must continue strengthening monitoring systems, quarantine preparedness and public awareness to prevent panic as well as complacency. At the same time, international cooperation remains crucial. Global health crises cannot be addressed in isolation, and coordinated action between governments, health agencies and research institutions is essential to contain the outbreak before it escalates further.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

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Modi’s Europe Push Redefines India’s Global Strategy

From green technologies and semiconductors to defence cooperation, energy security, Arctic research and supply-chain resilience, the PM Modi’s tour underlined New Delhi’s determination to build trusted long-term partnerships with economically advanced and politically influential European powers



AMBASSADOR
ANIL TRIGUNAYAT

Prime Minister Narendra Modi paid a five-nation visit to Europe from May 15-20, which included a short and substantive visit to UAE and strategic outreach to Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy. He conferred with his counterparts not only from these host countries but also leaders

of the European Union and all five Nordic countries, including Finland, Denmark and Iceland, under the rubric of 3rd India-Nordic Summit which was held in Oslo, focusing on a green and Innovative strategic partnership. Sweden and Norway conferred their highest civilian award on PM Modi to acknowledge and reiterate the importance of India, the largest democracy and one of the fastest-growing and resilient major economies, despite unprecedented global churn and disruptions caused by the Eurasian and Middle Eastern wars. The Agricola Medal was conferred upon him by the Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO) in Rome. A total of 57 agreements and MoUs were signed, and according to Randhir Jaiswal, Spokesman of the Ministry of External Affairs, several deals worth at least \$ 40 bn were signed during various B2B interactions of the Prime Minister with local business leaders. The relationship with the Netherlands was turned into a strategic partnership and that with Italy into a Special Strategic Partnership, given the importance and the convenience of political, economic, technological and security interests with two major trading, inexpensive and technology partners in Europe.

Not only did he have bilateral meetings with the leaders of these countries but in Goteburg, Sweden he addressed a joint business meeting with Swedish Prime Minister and European Union Commission Chief Ursula Von der Leyen focussing on greater B2B engagement and investments in ‘Make in India for the world’ enterprise especially in the context of full activation of the India-EU Free Trade Agreement -the so called ‘Mother of All deals’ by the year end. In the Netherlands, apart from defence technology, 6G, critical minerals, semiconductors, green technologies the focus was also laid on collaboration in WAH- Water, Agriculture and Health sectors. The agreement between Tata and ASML Netherlands was path-breaking for India’s Semiconductor Mission given the global edge the ASML uniquely possesses in this techno domain. Tata Electronics and ASML will partner together for India’s first front-end semiconductor Fab in Gujarat. As bilateral relations have acquired a huge strategic matrix and impetus the two leaders agreed to establish a Strategic Partnership between the two countries to steer the critical projects.

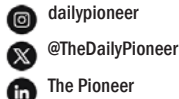
His visit to Norway was the first time in 43 years by any Indian Prime Minister. Norway is also an energy rich highly developed country with a unique model of saving and judiciously investing its sovereign wealth funds for future generations. As the energy disruptions due to Iran-Israel- US war have impacted India a great deal , discussions were also held on procuring hydrocarbons from Norway and even more from UAE -as New Delhi diversifies its supply chains and risks . Speaking at the India- Nordic Summit , PM Modi highlighted that during the last decade alone the bilateral trade with these countries had increased nearly four fold .He further emphasised “Investment funds from the Nordic countries are also becoming important partners in India’s rapid growth journey. Over the past decade, investments from the Nordic countries into India have grown by nearly 200 percent.”. As such the India Europe FTA-TEPA with Norway, Iceland, Switzerland and Leichestine, operationalised since October 2025 ,has created an additional platform for closer economic engagements among the businesses . Under this Agreement \$ 100 bn project investments are expected to be made in various sectors in India

The rapidly growing trade and investment have not only contributed to India’s growth story, but have also played a highly positive role in the economies of the Nordic countries and created thousands of new jobs. Building upon this strong foundation, we have



WHILE PERSONAL BONHOMIE AND RESPECT BETWEEN THE LEADERS DRIVES A RELATIONSHIP IN A TRUSTED MANNER, THE STRATEGIC DIMENSIONS OF THIS VERY IMPORTANT BILATERAL RELATIONSHIP FROM INDO-PACIFIC TO THE MEDITERRANEAN MUST BE APPRECIATED, AS INDIA FOCUSES ON IT EVEN MORE IN THE MARITIME DOMAIN

Anil Trigunayat is a former Indian Ambassador to Jordan, Libya and Malta and a Distinguished Fellow at Vivekananda International Foundation and USI of India



recently undertaken several important initiatives to take our relationship to the next level, added PM Modi.

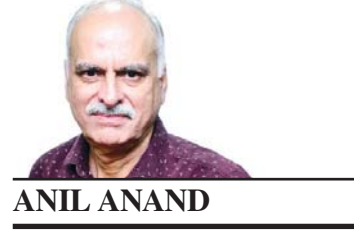
Each of these strategic partners have their unique strengths not only in green and innovative technologies and developmental partnership models where synergies have been found and a roadmap for collaboration and harnessing this potential even more has been institutionalised through five dozen agreements. PM Modi also referred to the key strategic geo-economic significance of each of our partners. He underscored that ‘we have decided to shape India-Nordic relations into a Green Technology and Innovation Strategic Partnership. Through this Green Technology Partnership, we will combine Iceland’s expertise in geothermal energy and fisheries, Norway’s strengths in the blue economy and the Arctic, and the maritime and sustainability expertise of all the Nordic countries with India’s scale, in order to secure a better future for the entire world. And through the formation of this unique strategic partnership between us, we will combine Sweden’s advanced manufacturing and defence capabilities, Finland’s expertise in telecommunications and digital technology, and Denmark’s strengths in cybersecurity and health-tech with India’s talent pool, to develop trusted solutions for the world.’. Same will apply in the new emerging geo-economically contested geography in the Arctic where Nordic countries have a critical role. As such India has been engaged in scientific expeditions and R& D in the Arctic and Antarctica and the Polar Regions with them which will be further intensified so that the shared prosperity through research and innovation could be achieved in a sustained manner.

As this ‘Sambandh’ ,which was also highlighted by PM Modi and Iceland Prime Minister as being a common word in Iceland and India , further intensifies the relationships. Both sides also discussed the wars in West Asia and Russia-Ukraine which have been a common concern and they expect India to play a greater role especially given Delhi’s special and strategic partnership with Moscow. PM Modi also assured them of India’s continued efforts to deescalate these crises. Since global governance and security architecture are in shambles and heading towards irrelevance, during all the interactions urgent need for their reforms and expansion of UNSC and India’s legitimate place in it were reemphasised.

On the final leg of the visit to Italy interestingly the gift of “Melody” Chocolates by PM Modi to PM Meloni got much greater social media attention. While personal bonhomie and respect between the leaders drives a relationship in a trusted manner, the strategic dimensions of this very important bilateral relationship from Indo-Pacific to the Mediterranean must be appreciated, as India focuses on it even more in the maritime domain. No wonder, it was upgraded to Special Strategic Partnership in less than three years since the exceptional convergences across the relationship spectrum from defence and security, to industry to economy to energy to high tech and design and fashion are all encompassed within the ‘The India-Italy Joint Strategic Action Plan 2025-29’ which provides a practical and futuristic framework for the partnership, which is being pursued in a time-bound manner. A bilateral trade target of 20 billion euros has been set from the current 14.6 Bn Euros. Italy is one of the most enthusiastic partners in the India Middle East Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC).

In a destabilising world, driven by utter unilateralism, India is continuing to expand its strategic engagement with Europe and the Nordic countries for a win-win cooperation through its strategic autonomy and multi-alignment policies for creating dependable constituencies and reliable techno friendships for the 21st century.

From hardline to handshake: RSS signals a Pakistan reset



ANIL ANAND

Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), mentor and strong umbilical link of the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), advocating peace efforts with Pakistan! And that too one year after Operation Sindoor was launched by the Indian Armed Forces in retaliation to the April 2025 terrorist attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir, which claimed lives of 26 innocent civilians and tourists. It might sound unbelievable under the gaze of the hardline and anti-Pakistan and Hindutva-agenda

driven Narendra Modi regime which had embarked on a hot-pursuit against Islamabad- at least for political consumption- ever since PM Modi’s futile attempt at extending an olive branch by inviting the then Pakistan Prime Minister Mr Nawaz Sharief, to his swearing-in ceremony in 2014. And later a failed unscheduled but certainly not unplanned sudden visit to Lahore to attend a family function at Mr Sharief’s residence.

Even after a decade, the insiders’ story on who advised Mr Modi to visit Pakistan contrary to his hardcore image, based on hyper-nationalism and Hindutva which was for everyone to see in the 2014 Lok Sabha poll campaign, has still to see light of the day. Or who fixed the timing for the same just in the beginning of his innings as Prime Minister. It did pay electoral dividend to the Modi-led BJP as it scored series of poll victories subsequently, pursuing the hardcore anti-Pakistan line. Nevertheless, it was a welcome move. It amplified the fact that the dialogue has no alternative. The only issue is how and when to hold peace talks. Here comes into play the surprise statement of one of the top leaders of the RSS. So, RSS general secretary Mr Dattaterya Hosabale’s recent call for peace talks with Pakistan took everyone, including a sizable section within the broader Sangh Parivar and hardcore Hindutva support base of the BJP, by surprise. It has given rise to questions whether the move is of the RSS’s own making or done at the behest of the Narendra Modi dispensation? Or more importantly, the RSS acted under an external pressure, ostensibly the USA given the overriding Donald Trump phenomena dictating terms?

Mr Hosabale’s statement some interesting accompaniments attached to it. It found immediate endorsement in the words of former army chief Gen M M Naravane who underlined the importance of maintaining communication and people-to-people ties between India and Pakistan. Ordinary citizens on both sides share similar everyday concerns and aspirations, he said giving strength to the RSS move.

Indo-Pakistan relation, war or peace, has never been short of theatrics, star-studded shows and high-profile summits. Nehru-Liaquat Pact, Shimla Agreement, Vajpayee-Musharraf summit, or the famous Amritsar-Lahore Bus yatra led by the then Prime Minister Mr Atal Bihari Vajpayee that included prominent persons from diverse fields including the evergreen cine-star, Mr Dev Anand, and last but not the least the controversial Inder Kumar Gujral doctrine. The Modi government did not dare to undertake a new initiative till the time the international scenario started undergoing dramatic changes particularly after Operation Sindoor and the West Asia conflict involving Iran, USA and Israel directly, and Pakistan, China and Russia by proxy. Is Mr Hosabale’s ice-breaking observation an indication of a fresh peace overture in the offing?

Yet, another significant and related development has taken place across the border with Pakistan, during the same while, deciding to rename some locations in Lahore to their historic Hindu, Sikh, Jain and British colonial era origin. It has been done under the garb of a massive Lahore Heritage Areas Revival project. If Mr Hosabale’s call for peace talks with Pakistan, and its endorsement by none other than a former army chief, has great significance particularly as it has received a silent endorsement from the Centre, no less important is restoration of old identity of some localities in Lahore.

Certainly, if RSS, found a fertile ground to establish itself by exploiting the sentiments in the aftermath of the 1947-partition and all-along pursued a hardline against Pakistan and a vice-versa role played by extremist Islamist elements on the other side of the border, and it now authors a peace initiative, its significance cannot be lost on anyone.

Does it reflect a tectonic shift in the Sangh Parivar- Narendra Modi government’s outlook towards Pakistan? What has led to this sudden yearning for peace talks with Islamabad, and the sudden love of Pakistan’s current dispensation for Hindu-Sikh-Jain heritage after its systematic destruction in pandering to the hardcore anti-India and anti-Hindu sentiment? Past history suggests that no peace effort, including ceasefire after the wars, between India and Pakistan has taken place without external pressure or mediation. It will be a naive to think that the RSS acted on its own to open a window for the Narendra Modi government to act, thereby shunning the hardcore image of the Sangh Parivar and the central dispensation. By doing so the RSS seems to have not only taken load of Prime Minister Mr Modi’s shoulders but also opened a safe passage for him to wade into hitherto forbidden territory to initiative peace efforts.

Whatever be the reason or compulsion, a peace effort should be welcomed by all desiring peace in the Indian sub-continent. It is important given the vulnerability to become a flash-point and added interest shown by the world-powers due to its strategic location. Despite the fact that Mr Modi, through his sheer dominance, has created a situation where RSS needs him more than he needs the RSS, the Sangh coming on board on a sensitive issue such as peace-talks with Pakistan, is a tactical move of great significance for him also. These are the starting moments. How would Mr Hosabale’s advocacy for peace with Pakistan or the restoration of old symbols particularly of Hindus, Jains and Sikhs in Lahore to be followed elsewhere in Pakistan also (as claimed in reports from Pakistan), really unfold and lay the table for peace talks, will be keenly watched.

All Prime Ministers, since 1947, including Mr Modi did take initiatives at restoration of peace with Pakistan. In fact, he went a mile ahead, keeping aside his hardcore ideological beliefs and Hindutva based politics, to visit Pakistan which many of his predecessors either avoided (for good reasons) or did not get an opportunity to do so, speaks volumes about the necessity for peace between Indian and Pakistan. This is so given the strategic location of the sub-continent and ever-growing interest of super-powers namely USA, China and Russia. This is not to suggest that hot-pursuit will not be an option if Pakistan indulged in any misadventure, directly or indirectly.

“You can change friends, but not neighbours.” Former Prime Minister Mr Vajpayee’s golden words hold significance and should be rooted in any future peace endeavour with Pakistan. The other side must realise that it needs two to tango and Pakistan has much to deliver to establish its credibility.

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Tiny mites, hidden viruses, and a growing threat to wheat crops



MRITUNJOY
BARMAN

hidden agricultural threat that remains largely unknown outside research circles: microscopic wheat curl mites and the dangerous viruses they transmit. Recent research from the University of Nebraska-Lincoln in the United States has shed light on how these mite-transmitted viruses are spreading not only through wheat but also through other cereal crops such as barley, oats, rye, and triticale. The findings have important implications for countries like India, where mixed cropping systems, climate variability, and fragmented agricultural practices may create ideal conditions for these diseases to spread silently before erupting into full-scale outbreaks. The study focused on what scientists call the Wheat Streak Mosaic Disease Complex, a group of viral diseases spread by wheat curl mites. These tiny pests are invisible to the naked eye, but the damage they cause can be enormous. Infected plants develop yellow streaks, become stunted, and suffer severe reductions in grain yield. In major outbreaks,

entire fields can become economically unviable. In the United States alone, wheat curl mite-transmitted viruses are estimated to cause annual losses worth \$50-100 million. A single infected field can lose between 50 and 80 percent of its yield. If a similar outbreak were to occur in India, the consequences could be devastating for both farmers and consumers. The danger lies not only in the viruses themselves but also in the way they survive between cropping seasons. Researchers describe the existence of a “green bridge” - a network of forage crops, volunteer wheat plants, grasses, and cereal crops that allow mites and viruses to persist throughout the year. In India’s agricultural landscape, where multiple crops often overlap across seasons, such conditions already exist on a large scale. What makes the threat especially alarming is that India currently has no comprehensive surveillance system for these viruses. Globally, wheat curl mite-transmitted viruses have already been documented in at least 25 countries across six continents, including the United States, Iran, Kazakhstan, Australia, Turkey, and several European and Latin American nations. Yet India, despite being the world’s second-largest wheat producer, officially shows zero documented cases. This absence of data should not be mistaken for safety. Scientists warn that it likely reflects a complete lack of systematic monitoring rather than the actual absence of disease. In many cases, symptoms caused by these viruses resemble drought stress, nutrient deficiency, or fungal infections. Farmers may dismiss the early warning



signs without realising that a viral outbreak is taking hold. India’s vulnerability is unique because of the sheer scale and structure of its wheat economy. The country produces nearly 100 million tonnes of wheat annually, valued at more than 72 lakh crore. Unlike large mechanised farms in North America, Indian wheat cultivation is spread across millions of small and marginal farmers, particularly in Punjab, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh. These farmers often rely on mixed cropping systems and informal seed exchanges, conditions that can unknowingly accelerate disease spread. A severe outbreak affecting even a fraction of India’s wheat-growing regions could trigger widespread economic distress. For small farmers already struggling with rising input costs and climate uncertainty, a 50-80 percent crop loss would not simply mean lower profits; it could mean debt, poverty, and food insecurity. The threat also

extends beyond agriculture into the broader economy. Wheat price inflation can quickly affect household budgets, government food distribution systems, and national reserves. Climate change is further increasing the risk. Wheat curl mites thrive in cool and dry conditions and survive on alternative host plants during off-seasons. Warmer winters and shifting rainfall patterns are extending their survival periods and expanding the range in which they can thrive. In South Asia’s densely cultivated agricultural zones, mites may now survive year-round instead of dying off seasonally. Another major challenge is the lack of diagnostic infrastructure. Detecting these viruses requires advanced molecular tools and trained specialists. India, despite its strong agricultural research institutions, has no dedicated regional effort focused specifically on wheat curl mite-transmitted viruses. This gap in preparedness could prove extremely costly. Scientists warn that by the time visible symptoms become widespread, the disease may already have spread across multiple districts or states. Without baseline surveillance data, authorities cannot estimate infection levels, identify hotspots, or implement targeted containment strategies. The problem is not confined to India alone. South Asia as a region remains dangerously underprepared. Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Nepal also depend heavily on wheat but possess limited research and monitoring capacity. Since plant diseases do not respect national borders, regional coordination will be essential. Experts are now calling for urgent preventive action

before the disease reaches crisis levels. The first step is nationwide surveillance across major wheat-growing states using modern molecular diagnostic tools. India also needs regional laboratories capable of identifying both the viruses and the mites that spread them. Equally important is the development of resistant wheat varieties. Scientists must begin screening Indian wheat strains to determine which are vulnerable and which possess natural resistance. For a country where wheat is central to food security and rural livelihoods, this is not an optional precaution but a national necessity. The warning signs are already visible globally. The disease has spread steadily across continents, moving closer to South Asia through trade routes, climate shifts, and interconnected agricultural systems. The question is no longer whether India will eventually encounter wheat curl mite-transmitted viruses. The real question is whether the country will act early enough to prevent a silent biological threat from becoming a full-scale food and economic crisis. Tiny mites may seem insignificant, but history has repeatedly shown that some of the greatest threats to food security begin invisibly. India still has time to prepare - but that window may not remain open for long.

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Order Order

Justice Meenakshi named for Patna HC Chief Justice

The Supreme Court collegium has recommended the appointment of Justice Meenakshi M Rai, a judge of the Sikkim High Court, as the next Chief Justice of the Patna High Court.

The recommendation was made in view of the retirement of the incumbent chief justice on June 4, according to a statement uploaded on the apex court website.

The collegium, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, held its meeting on May 22, it said.

"The Supreme Court collegium, in its meeting held on May 22, has recommended appointment of Justice Meenakshi M Rai, judge, High Court of Sikkim, as Chief Justice, High Court of Judicature at Patna, consequent upon retirement of incumbent Chief Justice on June 4, 2026," the statement said.



SP corporator Lalit sworn in after court order in UP

SP leader Lalit Kishore Tiwari was finally sworn in as a corporator at the Lucknow Municipal Corporation on Sunday, days after the Allahabad High Court froze Mayor Sushma Kharkwal's powers over a five-month delay in administering the oath.

Mayor Sushma Kharkwal said, "As per the High Court's directions, the oath-taking ceremony was held today related to Ward Number 73, Faizullaganj."

Explaining the delay, she said, "Our programme was already fixed a month ago. Suddenly, on 'Bada Mangal', I fell ill and was admitted to the Command Hospital. I was discharged from the hospital yesterday evening, and today we administered the oath to Lalit Kishore Tiwari." The dispute relates to the Ward Number 73 Faizullaganj municipal election in 2023.

In the local polls, BJP candidate Pradeep Kumar Shukla defeated SP candidate Lalit Kishor Tiwari.



Lucknow Mayor Sushma Kharkwal



Accused Shubham sent to judicial custody till June 6

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Sunday sent accused Shubham Khairnar to judicial custody till June 6 in the NEET paper leak case.

Special Judge Ruchi Aggarwal Asrani allowed the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) plea seeking judicial custody of the accused.

The federal agency said that the accused persons, including Khairnar, were "actively" involved in the leakage of NEET-UG 2026 examination questions prior to the commencement of the examination.

In its remand paper, the CBI said, "For the purpose of conducting investigation, the arrested accused persons are required to be in judicial custody to prevent tampering with evidence and influence upon witnesses connected with the investigation."



The agency said that judicial custody was also needed to prevent the accused from absconding, destroying physical or digital evidence, and engaging in "further commission of similar offences involving leakage of

questions." "The case is currently at the initial stage of investigation, and judicial custody is required in the interest of the case. It is further submitted that the police custody remand may be required (of Kairnar) in the

investigation again, as per the legal provisions, depending on developments in the case," the plea said.

Earlier, on May 14, a court had sent Khairnar and four others to CBI custody for seven days, observing that

2008 railway exam assault: Raj Thackeray's role in instigating attack not proved, says Court

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane

A Thane court, while acquitting Raj Thackeray and others in a 2008 case of alleged assault on Railway Recruitment Board examinees at Kalyan station, has observed that the prosecution failed to prove MNS chief's presence or that he incited the attack.

The CD containing the alleged speech of Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief Thackeray was never produced or proved in court, and as admitted by the investigation officer, was "left gathering dust" in the police station from 2013 to 2026, rendering it devoid of any evidentiary value, the court observed in its May 21 order.

It was further acknowledged (during cross-examination) that the injuries sustained by witnesses could also have resulted from a stampede triggered by chaos in the large crowd, said



the court order, a copy of which was made available on Sunday.

Thane's Chief Judicial Magistrate Abhijit V Kulkarni acquitted Raj Thackeray (57) and five others — Akash Rajendra Kale, Santosh Nivritti Thackeray, Vishal Suresh Kamble, Kailash Prakash Choubey and Ganesh Prakash Choubey — in the 14-year-old case.

The court noted that the prosecution had completely failed to substantiate the charges beyond a reasonable doubt.

The case stemmed from

with wooden sticks allegedly barged in. Shouting "MNS Zindabad" slogans, the attackers questioned candidates about their native states and ordered them to flee while physically assaulting them, the prosecution alleged.

The Kalyan railway police subsequently registered an FIR under various Indian Penal Code sections on charges of rioting, voluntarily causing hurt, criminal intimidation, assaulting a public servant and common intention.

The prosecution alleged that the MNS activists carried out the violence following an instigating speech delivered by Raj Thackeray. But the case collapsed during the trial as key eyewitnesses, including the injured victims, failed to identify the accused persons in court.

CJM Kulkarni made crucial observations regarding the lack of evidence against the accused and the failure of the investigating agency.

the allegations indicated the role of an "organised gang" involved in leaking and circulating confidential examination papers for monetary gain.

Khairnar's custodial interrogation was extended by five days on May 20 after the CBI stated that the accused needed to be further examined to identify and apprehend other co-accused to whom he had sold the NEET-UG 2026 papers.

The agency also cited the need to recover and analyse digital devices and evidence, including communication records and financial trail connected to the "paper leak network".

The CBI had further submitted that the larger conspiracy and source of the leaked question paper had to be unearthed, and the accused had to be taken to various parts of the country, including Nasik in Maharashtra.

According to the CBI, Khairnar also had to be interrogated to identify locations where questions were revealed to certain candidates.

Meanwhile, court sources said that Pune-based physics lecturer Manisha Sanjay Havaladar, arrested on Friday, was presently in transit remand and is likely to be produced before the court concerned on Monday.

They added that five other accused will also be produced before the court after their CBI custody ends on May 25. The CBI has so far arrested 10 accused in the case.

The NEET (UG) 2026 exam for admission to undergraduate courses in medical colleges, held on May 3, was cancelled two days later amid allegations of paper leak.

The Government has asked the CBI to carry out a comprehensive inquiry into the "irregularities".

Delhi court orders framing charges against two CBI officials in corruption case



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has directed framing of corruption and conspiracy charges against two CBI officials, including a deputy superintendent of police (DSP), for allegedly compromising the integrity of investigation in certain cases on "extraneous pecuniary consideration".

Special Judge Atul Krishna Agrawal on Saturday also discharged a Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) inspector

and a private company, saying there was insufficient evidence against them and particularly allegations against the inspector bordered on suspicion but not grave suspicion.

According to the CBI, DSP R K Rishi, Inspector Kapil Dhanek, and Selection Grade-II (SG II) official Samir Kumar Singh, in conspiracy with two private persons and certain others, had been "compromising the integrity of investigation of certain cases on extraneous pecuniary consideration".

SC ratifies HC order on reinstating Aviation University official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Supreme Court in a recent order upheld Allahabad High Court's order on the administrative powers of Rajiv Gandhi National Aviation University in Amethi. The apex court on May 21, has passed a verdict in favour of the First Registrar Jitendra Singh, while upholding the operative directions of the Division Bench of Allahabad High Court.

The Bench clarified that Section 46(b) of the Act, which empowered the Visitor to appoint the First Registrar, had to be read with Section 16 of the General Clauses Act,

1897, under which the authority having power to appoint also possesses the power to terminate unless a contrary intention appears.

However, the Court declined to interfere with the operative relief granted to the First Registrar considering the expiry of his tenure and the prolonged litigation between the parties.

The Ministry of Civil Aviation terminated Jitendra Singh on January 8, 2020, citing allegations of insubordination and indiscipline, behind his back & without conducting any inquiry or issuing show cause. In September 2021, the High Court quashed the illegal



Orders passed by Ministry of Civil Aviation finding them "Stigmatic" & "Punitive" and ordered reinstatement with full consequential benefits. An appeal was filed before the Division Bench of the

High Court, which upheld the Order of Single Bench and terming it Illegal, and remitting the case to the University to pass fresh orders in 2 months.

In December 2021, Singh

reinstated into the Service by the Hon'ble President of India as Visitor RGNAU. But on the same day he was placed under suspending pending inquiry. A hushed up enquiry was conducted by MoCA (on 1 hour video conference) and again a termination order was passed with retrospective effect. In May 2024, the Allahabad High Court quashed the Ministry's 2022 revised termination order. The High Court ruled that the Ministry of Civil Aviation has zero jurisdiction over disciplinary actions of University staff, and that the Visitor (President of India) has no role in such internal employee matters.

Champawat fake gang-rape case: Court rejects bail applications of 4 accused

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Champawat

A special sessions court has rejected the bail applications of four accused in connection with the fake gang-rape case, officials said.

Special Sessions Judge Anuj Kumar Sangal on Saturday denied bail to Kamal Rawat, his female friend Arjita Rai, Congress state secretary Anand Mahra and Bablu Ram, Government Counsel Vidyadhar Joshi told media.

The court passed the order after hearing arguments from both sides. The four accused are currently lodged



in the Pithoragarh district jail.

Police arrested Kamal Rawat and Arjita Rai on May 8, while Anand Mahra and Bablu Ram were caught on May 13. A 16-year-old girl had lodged a complaint alleging that three armed men gang-raped her on the night

of May 5 in the Salli village. Police registered a case against the three named individuals, including a former BJP leader, the next day.

But investigations revealed that the gang-rape allegations were "completely false and fabricated". Police found that the group had hatched a premeditated conspiracy to frame the individuals.

Following the revelation, police registered a fresh case against the five main conspirators. Police have already arrested four of the individuals.

Delhi court grants bail to advocate held with pistols at Tis Hazari complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has granted bail to an advocate arrested under the Arms Act after two pistols and eight cartridges were allegedly recovered from a trolley bag he was carrying at the Tis Hazari court complex earlier this week.

Judicial Magistrate Preeti Rajoria allowed the bail plea of the accused, Harsh, observing that his continued incarceration was not necessary merely for the purpose of judicial custody.

In an order dated May 23, the court said, "At this stage, continued incarceration of accused Harsh does not appear to be necessary merely for the purpose of judicial custody, particularly when no further custodial interrogation has been sought by the IO."

"Accordingly, without commenting upon the merits of the case, the present bail application is allowed," it added.

The court noted that while



the issue of the accused's knowledge and conscious possession of the alleged illegal arms would be a matter of trial, certain circumstances highlighted by the defence could not be ignored at the stage of bail consideration.

"The contention raised on behalf of the accused regarding lack of knowledge and conscious possession cannot be conclusively adjudicated at this stage since they are matters of trial," the magistrate said.

Appearing for the accused, the defence counsel argued

that Harsh had allowed the trolley bag to be scanned at the court entry gate, which, it claimed, indicated a lack of awareness about the alleged weapons.

The investigating officer informed the court that the accused had already joined the probe and had taken the police team to locations connected with another accused, Ram Singh, who is currently absconding.

The IO also stated that no further police custody remand was being sought and judicial custody had been requested instead.

Odisha court sentences 19 to life imprisonment in Nabarangpur clash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nabarangpur

Nineteen people were sentenced to life imprisonment by a court in Odisha's Nabarangpur district in a 2016 clash between two groups that left three persons dead.

Additional District Judge Sunita Patnaik pronounced the verdict on Saturday after examining witnesses, testimonies and documentary evidence.

The incident happened on July 16, 2016, at Baunshbeda village in Umerkot block following a dispute over the cultivation of Government land.

According to the prosecution, Balamram Harijan of Baunshbeda village had been cultivating a patch of Government land at nearby Telgaon village. Tribal villagers opposed it and urged the Forest Department to plant saplings there.

Balamram allegedly uprooted the saplings, triggering tension in the area.

Subsequently, a group of



tribal villagers went to Balamram's house to confront him. During the altercation, Balamram allegedly attacked one Gurubaru Bhatra with a knife, while another accused, Ganapati Harijan, allegedly slit the throat of one Fagunu Bhatra, killing him on the spot.

Gurubaru, who suffered critical injuries, later died at a hospital after recording a dying declaration before police, the prosecution said.

Following the incident, hundreds of tribal villagers allegedly surrounded

Balamram's house, pelted stones and set the structure on fire. As Balamram attempted to escape through the roof, he was allegedly caught by the mob and beaten to death, according to the prosecution.

Police registered two separate cases and arrested the accused persons, Government counsel Ashok Kumar Padhi said.

After a prolonged trial, the court convicted 19 persons in the case and sentenced them to life imprisonment, he said.

Sikkim CM congratulates Justice Rai on being appointed CJ of Patna HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gangtok

Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang has congratulated Justice Meenakshi Madan Rai on her elevation as the Chief Justice of Patna High Court, calling it a "historic" and proud moment for the people of Sikkim.

The chief minister, in a Facebook post, stated that it is a matter of "immense pride, honour, and happiness" for the state that Justice Meenakshi Madan Rai is set to assume one of the highest judicial positions in the country.

He highlighted that Justice Rai is the first woman judge from Sikkim to attain the distinguished position of Chief Justice of a high court, describing her elevation as a historic milestone and a reflection of her unwavering dedication, integrity, wisdom, and distinguished service to the judiciary.



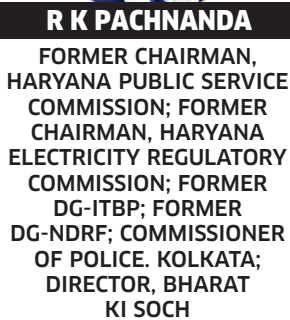
Justice Rai is at present a judge of the Sikkim High Court. Tamang further said that her remarkable achievement would serve as an inspiration to the people of Sikkim and aspiring individuals across the nation.

On behalf of the Government and people of Sikkim, the chief minister conveyed his warmest greetings and best wishes to Justice Rai for a successful and exemplary tenure ahead.

He also expressed confidence that under her leadership, the Patna High Court would continue to uphold the highest traditions of justice, fairness, and constitutional values with distinction.

Panchatantra (Mitra bheda)

The *Manusmriti* (10.114) states that in difficult



This profound aphorism conveys that all state power - military strength, administrative

As good citizens, we must ensure and follow the Prime Minister's appeal, just as we voluntarily followed the lockdown and COVID protocols, united in spirit and solidarity towards the well-being and protection of one and all. The Prime Minister's clarion call is, hence, a sincere and honest effort for the future prosperity of the nation and the welfare of all Indians.

Note: These terms come from Manipuri, one of India's 22 Scheduled Languages

Harappan seals and cubical weights found at Mesopotamian sites like Ur and Kish attest to the presence of Harappan merchants in Mesopotamia. Cotton, first cultivated in the Sindhu-Saraswati valley, was traded as raw fibre and woven textiles, thereby linking the Harappans to an expansive commercial circuit.

More serves as India's key land port, linking trade across India, Myanmar, China, and Thailand, and continuing the historic Southwest Silk Road corridor. Now, under India's Act East Policy, the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway is restoring Manipur's ancient role as a gateway between South and Southeast Asia.

	Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1	Which ancient port city was a major hub for trade with the Roman and Arab Empires on the west coast of India?	Arikamedu	Bharuch	Korkai	Dholavira
2	Which of the following was a major export item from ancient India to West Asia?	Wine	Horses	Black Pepper	Lapis Lazuli
3	Which was a standard unit of measurement for gold and often functioned as a currency during the Chola and Pandyan dynasties?	Kalanju	Karshapana	Jital	Fanam
4	Which of them formed a major source of revenue for the monarchy in ancient India?	War Booty	Land Revenue	Forest Produce	Religious Funds
5	Which crop was introduced to India by the Sufi saint, Baba Budan, by smuggling a few beans from Yemen and planting them in Karnataka?	Arecanut	Banana	Coffee	Dates

Answers: 1 - B, 2 - C, 3 - A, 4 - B, 5 - C

MORAL OF THE STORY: Don't tell lies and deceive others

FROM THE WORLD

PHILIPPINES

One dead as building falls

A nine-story building under construction in a city north of the Philippine Capital collapsed before dawn on Sunday, leaving at least one Malaysian tourist dead and at least 21 mostly workers trapped in the rubble, officials said. Two were located alive but could not be immediately extricated.

At least 24 workers either managed to dash out of the building, where they mostly slept on the ground floor, or were rescued after it crumbled to the ground around 2:30 am in a crowded neighbourhood of budget hotels, cafes, spas and rural houses outside a former US Air Force base, officials said. A Malaysian tourist died, and another guest was injured in a lodging house, which was partly hit by debris from the collapsing building in Angeles City in Pampanga province, Fire Superintendent Maria Lea Sajili said.

PAKISTAN

11 terrorists killed by forces

Security forces killed 11 terrorists in the last two days in northwest Pakistan, the army said on Sunday. The security forces conducted intelligence-based operations in the North Waziristan district of the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province, according to a statement issued by the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR): the media wing of the Pakistan Army. Multiple terrorist locations were targeted during the operations in the Datta Khel area of the district, it said. "Following intense and fierce exchanges of fire, eleven khawarij belonging to Fitna-al-Khawarij were effectively neutralised," it added. Earlier this week, the military media wing said security forces had killed another 22 terrorists in the district. In a separate development on Sunday, unidentified terrorists killed four local peace committee members in Dera Ismail Khan district.

20 killed in Balochistan shuttle train explosion; BLA claims responsibility

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

At least 20 people are feared dead and many injured after a powerful explosion ripped through a shuttle train in Pakistan's Balochistan province on Sunday, officials said.

The banned Baloch Liberation Army (BLA) has claimed responsibility for the blast.

The shuttle train was heading from Quetta Cantonment to the railway station in the city when it was targeted near Chaman Phatak, the state-run Associated Press of Pakistan reported.

A BLA spokesperson has said the attack was carried out as the train was transporting military personnel from the cantonment area.

While the government has officially confirmed 14 deaths so far, including three personnel of the Frontier Corps, officials say that the toll is likely to increase.

Local police officials, however, have said that 20 people are feared dead, even though some media reports have already reported a higher toll.

Pakistan's Railways Minister Hanif Abbasi has said there were civilian pas-



sengers in the shuttle train, and the explosion hit the engine and three coaches.

The noise and impact of the explosion were so loud that windshields of vehicles in the area and window glasses of nearby buildings were left shattered.

A large number of passengers in the train were people looking forward to catching connecting trains to their home stations for the upcoming Eid festival, officials said.

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif has condemned the

incident and said, "Such cowardly acts of terrorism cannot weaken the resolve of the people of Pakistan".

He further said, "We remain steadfast in our determination to eliminate terrorism in all its forms and manifestations."

Railway authorities, according to a report in Geo News, stopped the Peshawar-bound Jaffar Express at Quetta Railway Station after the blast as a precautionary measure.

Babar Yousafzai, the

spokesperson to the home ministry, said that all relevant institutions have been placed on high alert following the explosion, as he urged the public not to gather near the blast site to ensure safety and allow emergency teams to carry out rescue operations without obstruction.

The region has witnessed a few such incidents in the past several years. In November 2024, at least 32 people were killed, and scores were injured when a suicide bomber hit the Quetta Cantt Railway Station.

China probes safety lapses after mine blast kills 82

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Qinyuan (China)

Authorities in northern China were investigating a coal mine operator with a focus on safety lapses, as rescuers searched for those missing in the country's deadliest coal mine explosion in recent years, which killed at least 82 people.

An Associated Press reporter witnessed police and security guarding the entrance to the mining facility located in Qinyuan county in the city of Changzhi as emergency vehicles were on site.

Hundreds of emergency responders and medical personnel were sent to help with rescue efforts, state media reported. Rescuers were taking turns to go down the mine shaft, according to the official Xinhua News Agency, facing hurdles including flooded tunnels.

Chinese President Xi Jinping called for a thorough investigation and accountability of those responsible following the explosion on Friday evening at the Liushenyu coal mine in the northern province of Shanxi.

Two were missing, and dozens of miners were hospitalised, local officials said



late Saturday. The death toll was revised down from 90, with officials blaming "chaotic" scenes in the aftermath and inaccurate information provided by the mine operator as a reason.

Some hospitalised miners recalled seeing smoke and blacking out, according to state media reports. Many among the injured were hurt by toxic gas.

The inland Shanxi province, located southwest of Beijing with a population of around 34 million, is China's main coal-mining area.

A few hundred meters (yards) from the mine lies the village of Shangzhuang, where some of the miners who work at the site live, including some of the victims, residents said.

The village includes a

single main street through which mining trucks pass. On both sides stand two-story houses, some with red-tiled roofs. Some of them are divided into separate rooms and rented out to people, including miners.

After the explosion, other mines in the area shut down, and some miners left, while others stayed behind waiting to receive their pay, residents said.

Wang Linjun, a coal miner at Liushenyu, said he was at home when the gas explosion occurred.

"My heart is very heavy," he told the AP. "Thinking that those who eat together and work together are suddenly gone, no one would feel good," Wang said. He does not want to continue at the job, but doesn't know where to go.

Gunman, bystander shot near White House; both critical

DARLENE SUPERVILLE/
ALANNA DURKIN RICHER
■ Washington

The US Secret Service shot a person near the White House and a bystander was also shot, a law enforcement official said.

Both individuals were said to be in critical condition, according to the official, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to discuss the investigation.

Journalists working at the White House on Saturday reported hearing a series of gunshots and were told to seek shelter inside the press briefing room.

On X, the Secret Service said it was "aware of reports of shots fired near 17th Street and Pennsylvania Avenue NW" — one block from the White House — and was "working to corroborate the information with personnel on the ground". It said it will have an update shortly.

In a social media post, FBI Director Kash Patel said officers were responding to shots fired and said he would "update the public as we're able".

President Donald Trump was inside the White House at the time.



In a post shared on X, Selina Wang, the senior White House correspondent for ABC News, shared dramatic video of the moment she said she heard what "sounded like dozens of gunshots" and ducked for cover. Writing that she had been performing a task that reporters at the White House do day in and day out — filming themselves on a cellphone, for a social media post — Wang's video shows her speaking for a few seconds about Trump's statements earlier Saturday

about a potential Iran deal.

As the sounds of gunfire are heard in the background, Wang's eyes grow wider, and she ducks down in the media tent, which is among those situated in a line along the White House driveway where broadcasters film their reports. On X, Wang's video had been shared thousands of times as of Saturday evening and viewed at least 3 million times.

The Metropolitan Police Department said on its X Account

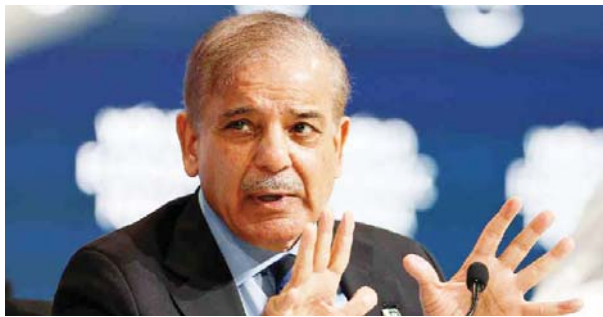
that the Secret Service was working the scene and cautioned people to avoid the area. The scene is near where a gunman ambushed two members of the West Virginia National Guard last November.

US Army Specialist Sarah Beckstrom, 20, died from her wounds. Andrew Wolfe, then 24, was critically wounded. Rahmanullah Lakanwal has been charged in that incident.

The gunfire Saturday comes nearly a month after what law enforcement authorities said was an attempted assassination of the president on April 25 as he attended the annual White House Correspondents' Association Dinner at a Washington hotel. Cole Tomas Allen, of Torrance, California, recently pleaded not guilty to charges that he attempted to kill Trump and remains in federal custody.

Following that scare, Secret Service officers shot a suspect they said had fired at officers near the Washington Monument, also near the White House. Michael Marx, 45, of Midland, Texas, was charged in a complaint filed in the US District Court in connection with the May 4 shooting. A teenage bystander was wounded in that incident. (AP)

Pakistan hopes to host next US-Iran peace talks soon: PM Sharif



SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Pakistan's Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Sunday said that Islamabad hopes to host the next round of peace talks between Tehran and Washington very soon.

He praised US President Donald Trump for "his extraordinary efforts to pursue peace" in West Asia, while he committed that Pakistan will continue efforts for peace in the region.

Trump, on Saturday, held a phone call with the leaders of Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkiye, Egypt, the United Arab Emirates, Jordan, Bahrain and Pakistan.

For Pakistan, it was Army chief Field Marshal Asim Munir who was on the call, said Sharif.

Sharif, who is currently on a visit to China, also praised the field marshal, saying: "I greatly appreciate his tireless efforts during the entire process."

The Pakistan PM said in a statement on X: "The discussions provided a useful opportunity to exchange views on the current regional situation and how to move the ongoing peace efforts forward to bring lasting peace in the region. Pakistan will continue its peace efforts with utmost sincerity, and we hope to host the next

round of talks very soon."

Munir was in Tehran till late Saturday evening, holding talks with top Iranian leaders on accelerating efforts to achieve a "conclusive agreement" between the US and Iran to bring peace in West Asia.

As Munir wrapped up his trip, Trump said in a statement on Truth Social: "An agreement has been largely negotiated, subject to finalisation between the United States of America, the Islamic Republic of Iran, and the various other countries."

Trump also said that he had a separate phone call with Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, "which, likewise, went very well".

He added that the "final aspects and details of the deal are currently being discussed, and will be announced shortly".

Pakistan has emerged as a mediator in the ongoing conflict, which has triggered severe energy shortages and affected economies worldwide.

Several analysts say that Islamabad enjoys the confidence of both Tehran and Washington.

Islamabad hosted senior leaders of both sides last month for talks, the first of its kind since 1979, but the parties failed to clinch a peace deal. (PTI)

Russia uses hypersonic Oreshnik missile in mass attack on Kyiv



SAMYA KULLAB/
VASILISA STEPANENKO
■ Kyiv

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on Sunday that Russia used the powerful hypersonic Oreshnik ballistic missile during a mass drone and missile attack on Kyiv on Sunday that killed at least two people, marking the third time the weapon has been used in the four-year war.

The intense aerial assault damaged buildings across the Ukrainian Capital, including near Government offices, residential buildings, schools, and a market, Ukrainian authorities said. At least 83 people were wounded in the attack.

The Oreshnik, which is capable of carrying nuclear or conventional warheads, struck the city of Bila Tserkva in the Kyiv region, Zelenskyy said in a post on Telegram. The target was not immediately clear. Russia's Defence Ministry

on Sunday confirmed it used the Oreshnik, as well as other missile types, to strike Ukrainian "military command and control facilities," air bases and military industrial enterprises. It did not specify where the targets were. Ministry officials later told Russian media that no civilian sites were targeted in the overnight strike, the Tass state agency reported on Sunday.

In a statement on social media, the ministry said the attack was retaliation for Ukrainian attacks on "civilian facilities on Russian territory," without immediately giving details.

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Friday denounced a drone strike on a college dormitory in Russian-occupied eastern Ukraine, which Moscow blames on Kyiv, and ordered the Russian military to submit its proposals for retaliation. He said there were no military or law enforcement facilities near the college. (AP)

Britain's navy prepares to clear mines in Strait of Hormuz

EMMA BURROWS
■ Aboard The RFA Lyme Bay

Aboard the RFA Lyme Bay docked off the coast of Gibraltar, hundreds of British sailors are waiting to be deployed for a mine-clearing mission to the Strait of Hormuz that is still in doubt.

US President Donald Trump has lashed out at allies for not doing more to support the 'United States' war effort in Iran, whose chokehold on the strait has crippled international shipping and sent energy prices soaring. In March, Trump told NATO allies to "go get your own oil" and secure the strait themselves.

On the southern tip of the Iberian Peninsula, in the British Overseas



Territory of Gibraltar, the UK's Royal Navy is preparing to do that - but only once a peace agreement is reached.

Trump said Saturday that a deal with Iran has been "largely negotiated" after

calls with Israel and other allies in the region, but it still needs finalising.

Britain's Armed Forces Minister Al Carns took a small group of reporters to visit the RFA Lyme Bay as it prepares for a possible international operation, led by the UK and France, to secure the strait.

As Carns spoke, the amphibious landing vessel, docked at the gateway to the Mediterranean, was being loaded with ammunition and mine-hunting sea drones equipped with sonar.

With a crew of several hundred sailors, the RFA Lyme Bay will soon depart Gibraltar to link up with the UK destroyer HMS Dragon and allied ships for air support before sailing through the Suez Canal to the Persian Gulf. (AP)

Syria holds legislative elections in Kurdish-majority northeast

HOGIR AL ABDO/
KAREEM CHEHAYEB
■ Hassakeh (Syria)

Syria held follow-up parliamentary elections on Sunday in the Kurdish-majority northeastern province of Hassakeh and the town of Kobani, areas that were reintegrated under Government control after fighting in January.

Other parts of Syria voted for the People's Assembly last October, almost a year after the Assad dynasty was ousted in a rebel offensive. However, at that point, large



swaths of the country's northeastern region were still under the control of the Kurdish-led Syrian Democratic Forces, notably Hassakeh and Kobani.

The country is still reeling from the devastating

impact of its uprising-turned-civil war from 2011 until 2024, as scepticism remains among large segments of its minorities now living under Islamist rule, while millions of Syrians live in poverty. (AP)

China-Nepal team extracts first full depth ice core from Everest summit

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Beijing

A joint China-Nepal scientific expedition has completed the first full-depth ice core drilling at the summit of Mt Everest to collect samples for understanding climate and environmental changes in ultra-high-altitude areas.

Members of the joint expedition conducted scientific sampling work, including ice core drilling, on the world's tallest mountain at an altitude of 8,848.86 metres.

It took about two hours for the expedition team on Thursday to complete the



first-ever full-depth ice core extraction from the summit, China's state-run Global Times reported.

The team collected ice core and snow core samples across multiple altitude gradients on the way down.

The samples will be transported to laboratories under low-temperature preserva-

tion conditions for research on climate and environmental changes in the world's highest region, cryosphere evolution, and atmospheric records at extreme altitudes, the newspaper said.

The collected samples are expected to help researchers better understand climate and environmental changes in ultra-high-altitude areas, the boundary of the Indian monsoon's influence, the transport pathways of pollutants into high-altitude regions, and differences in climate responses between the northern and southern slopes of Mt Everest.

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NEW DELHI | MONDAY | MAY 25, 2026

BUSINESS13

India's fuel austerity hits demand outlook

Annual product growth forecast cut 40 per cent

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's transportation fuel demand growth is expected to slow sharply in the second half of 2026 as Government-led fuel conservation measures, elevated crude oil prices and a weakening rupee weigh on mobility and consumption trends, according to energy analysts.

Petrol and diesel prices have been hiked by about ₹5 per litre each in three instalments since May 15 as oil companies passed on a part of soaring international oil prices to consumers. The price hikes came just as Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged citizens and Government departments to conserve fuel, encourage remote working and reduce non-essential travel as elevated energy prices pressure foreign exchange reserves and threaten to widen the current account deficit. This

together with higher prices is likely to have a sobering impact on fuel demand growth.

A report by Elif Binici, Lead Analyst (Modeling) at Kpler, revised down India's 2026 refined products demand growth forecast by about 77,000 barrels per day (kbd), or 39 per cent, to around 78 kbd from an earlier estimate of 128 kbd, citing weaker expected growth in

gasoline and diesel consumption.

Petrol demand faces the steepest downside risk, with growth projected to undershoot the earlier growth estimate by 25 kbd (from 63 kbd to 38 kbd). Petrol consumption is now estimated at 1010 kbd, down from 1035 kbdp amid weaker commuting activity, slower discretionary travel and Government fuel-saving

campaigns. Annual diesel demand growth was cut by around 20 kbd, while jet fuel demand growth was revised down nearly 50 per cent to about 6 kbd from 11 kbd previously, reflecting expectations of reduced air travel and tighter spending patterns.

"The revisions primarily reflect weaker expected growth in gasoline and diesel demand as higher costs, weaker mobility trends, and recent Government-led fuel conservation efforts increasingly feed into domestic transportation activity," according to the report.

The report said India's macro-economic backdrop had deteriorated since the escalation of the US-Iran conflict, with higher crude import costs, refinery expenses and rupee depreciation increasing pressure on inflation and state-run oil marketing companies (OMCs).

The rupee has weakened roughly 6 per cent since the start of the conflict and 10 per cent over the past year. At the same time, FX reserves have reportedly fallen approximately 4.3 per cent since late February as authorities attempt to stabilise the currency, contain imported inflation, and limit volatility in domestic fuel prices. Retail

petrol and diesel prices, largely frozen since 2022 despite higher global crude prices, were raised by about ₹5 per litre in three instalments during the last 10 days. However, the increases remain well below estimated breakeven levels for state-run retailers.

The current national average petrol price of ₹103 per litre remains far below estimated breakeven levels of nearly ₹125 per litre, while diesel prices near ₹94 per litre compare with estimated breakeven levels of ₹115-120 per litre.

Before the start of the price revision cycle, state-run fuel retailers were losing roughly ₹1,000 crore per day as elevated crude procurement costs and currency weakness continued to outpace retail prices. "The key issue is the inability of state-run retailers to pass through rising import costs quickly enough to restore profitability," the report said.

India's dependence on discounted Russian crude imports, currently estimated at around 1.9-2 million barrels per day, continues to provide a key stabilising force for the domestic fuel market amid ongoing geopolitical uncertainty in the Middle East, it added.

Coal India plans syngas projects near gas-based power

State-owned Coal India plans to set up coal-to-syngas production units either at pithead locations or adjacent to user industries such as fertiliser units, direct-reduced iron and gas-based power plants amid disruption in gas supplies due to the West Asia conflict, sources said.

Coal India Ltd (CIL), which accounts for over 80 per cent of domestic coal output, has already initiated steps to develop such coal-to-syngas facilities.

In line with the National Mission on Coal Gasification and the Government's vision to enhance domestic chemical and feedstock security, CIL intends to set up coal-to-syn-gas facilities to cater to the market demand for syn-gas in gas-based power plants/DRI or fertiliser plants, sources said.

The company plans to develop such facilities either on Build-Own-Operate (BOO) or Build-Operate-Maintain (BOM) basis, with syngas to be produced from coal by developers or consortia, they said.

Syngas serves as a versatile feedstock for the production of clean fuels, fertilisers, chemicals, and power generation. (PTI)

Uzbekistan seeks Indian investment in fintech, AI

Uzbekistan has created a business-friendly environment with targeted incentives for fintech, AI, and digital infrastructure companies, including those from India, Deputy Minister of Investment, Industry and Trade Shokhrukh Gulamov has said.

Government policies supporting special economic zones, joint ventures, and digital infrastructure investments further enhance Uzbekistan's appeal, he told media in an interview.

By leveraging these advantages, Indian firms can diversify outsourcing operations beyond traditional South Asian centres, optimise cost structures, and access a talent pool capable of supporting high-value services, he said.

This positions Uzbekistan as a strategic base for regional tech expansion and enhances bilateral economic engagement, he said.

"Uzbekistan provides targeted incentives for fintech, AI, and digital infrastructure firms. These include preferential tax regimes, access to special economic zones with ready digital infrastructure, and regulatory support for pilot projects," he said. (PTI)

Overseas travel spending by Indians falls to \$1.09 billion in March: RBI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) data showed Indians' overseas travel spending fell to \$121.43 million to \$1.09 billion in March compared to February. The outward remittances for travel were at \$1.3 billion in February and \$1.65 billion in January this year. Data showed that total outward remittances stood at \$2.59 billion in March 2026, of which travel accounted for the largest share at \$1.09 billion. The travel category under the LRS has been classified into business travel, pilgrimage, medical treatment, travel for education, and 'other travel'.

The RBI data on 'Outward Remittances under the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) for Resident Individuals' shows overseas spending by Indians under different categories, including travel, maintenance of close relatives, studies abroad, investments in equity and debt.

The data showed that

Indians spent \$623.05 million under the 'other travel' category, which includes holiday trips and international credit card settlements, during March. It accounted for nearly 57 per cent of the total travel outgo of \$1.09 billion. Spending on education-related travel (including fees, hostel expenses) totalled \$450.16 million in March, while expenditure on overseas business travel, pilgrimage and medical treatment totalled \$21.39 million.

The RBI data also showed that outbound remittances under the LRS towards maintenance of close relatives

stood at \$389.78 million in March, higher than \$266.18 million in February.

Further, the overseas spending under the head 'studies abroad', which includes transaction when an individual avails education services remotely without travelling abroad, such as fees for correspondence courses abroad, stood at \$151.71 million in March, lower than \$175.68 million in February and \$267.42 million in January.

The decline comes at a time when the Government has flagged concerns around rising outward remittances

and the pressure they place on India's foreign exchange outgo, particularly under the LRS. Overseas travel remains one of the largest components of outward remittances by resident Indians.

Under the LRS, resident individuals, including minors, are allowed to freely remit up to \$2,50,000 per financial year (April-March) for any permissible current or capital account transaction or a combination of both.

Against the backdrop of the West Asia conflict pushing oil prices higher and pulling down the rupee to record lows, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has urged people to reduce foreign travel and opt for car-pooling, among other measures. With lesser overseas travel, foreign exchange outgo will reduce, and that can help in curbing rupee depreciation.

Total outward remittances under the LRS during 2024-25 stood at \$29.56 billion, of which travel accounted for the largest share at \$16.96 billion.

NITI Aayog CEO calls for aligning education, skilling with economic needs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NITI Aayog CEO Nidhi Chibber has underlined the importance of continued efforts towards aligning education, skilling, and employment ecosystems with the evolving requirements of the economy, according to an official statement.

On 22nd May 2026, NITI

continues to play a pivotal role in India's economic development, and highlighted its growing contribution to economic resilience, export competitiveness, employment quality, global value chains, and potential to contribute to the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

The Committee decided to meet at regular intervals and focus on identifying actionable recommen-

NITI Aayog CEO Nidhi Chibber

Aayog convened the first meeting of the High Powered 'Education to Employment and Enterprise Standing Committee' under the chairpersonship of Chibber.

Speaking at the meeting, Chibber observed that India's demographic dividend presents opportunities to accelerate growth through appropriate policy measures to create productive employment and entrepreneurial opportunities for the youth.

According to the statement, the Committee noted that the services sector con-

ditions to enhance employability, foster entrepreneurship, strengthen industry-relevant skilling, and accelerate growth in the services sector.

The meeting concluded with a shared commitment to transform India's demographic dividend into a growth dividend, enhance coordinated action among the Centre, States, industry, academia, and the skilling ecosystem, and develop future-ready policy responses for bridging the gap between education, employment, and entrepreneurship.

Govt expands fuel dispenser verification to cover hydrogen, clean fuels

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Consumer Affairs Ministry has amended legal metrology rules to allow Government-approved testing centres to verify hydrogen, LPG, LNG and CNG fuel dispensers, expanding the country's measurement oversight framework as cleaner fuel adoption grows.

The Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution amended the Legal Metrology (Government

Approved Test Centre) Rules, 2013, bringing the total number of instrument categories verifiable through Government Approved Test Centres (GATCs) to 23 from 18.

Verification fees for petrol and diesel dispensers have been set at ₹5,000 per nozzle, while CNG, LPG, LNG and hydrogen dispensers will attract a higher fee of ₹10,000 per nozzle.

"The move is expected to enhance the availability of verification services, improve efficiency and support the

growing adoption of cleaner fuels across the country," the ministry said in a statement.

GATCs are approved private facilities with the technical expertise to carry out verification and re-verification of specified weights and measures under the Legal Metrology Act. The framework allows qualified private laboratories to expand national verification capacity beyond state Government resources.

Under the amended rules,

State Governments will be empowered to notify additional categories of instruments for GATC verification based on local requirements. Officers of the rank of Joint Secretary and above have also been authorised to approve related matters, aimed at cutting processing delays.

The ministry said the reforms would free up state legal metrology departments to focus on inspection, enforcement and consumer grievance redressal.

India should now focus on FTA implementation: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's next priority on the Free Trade Agreement (FTA) front should be practical implementation and helping exporters use these pacts, as the gap between the negotiated and used market access remains the country's weakest link, experts say.

They said that historically, India's FTA utilisation has hovered around 25 per cent, compared with 70-80 per cent in developed economies, and closing this gap is now the single highest-leverage trade policy reform available.

The immediate priority should be to ensure that these negotiated benefits translate into actual claims at the border, Didwania said.

"Hence, India's next FTA priority should be practical implementation, helping exporters use the agreements, defend against new trade barriers, and convert market access into sustained export growth," Gulzar Didwania, Partner, Deloitte India, said. India has so far implemented several trade pacts, includ-

ing those with Singapore, Japan, Korea, the UAE, Australia, ASEAN, and the EFTA bloc. It has also finalised such pacts with Oman, New Zealand, the European Union, and the UK.

The immediate priority should now be to ensure that these negotiated benefits translate into actual claims at the border, Didwania said.

"The policy narrative must now move decisively from FTA signing to FTA utilisation. India has already secured significant market-access outcomes, including duty-free access for 99 per cent of India's exports to the UK under CETA and market access for more than 99 per cent of India's exports by trade value under the India-EU FTA," he added.

Didwania also said that FTAs can help cushion the impact of geopolitical uncertainties on India's merchandise exports by creating alternative trade routes and improving access to multiple strategic markets. India's best approach would be to diversify export markets and products, deepen integration with

global value chains, and strengthen domestic manufacturing competitiveness to reduce external vulnerabilities, he said.

Rudra Kumar Pandey, Partner, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co, also stated that the most immediate priority is FTA utilisation. "The gap between market access negotiated and market access used remains India's weakest link," he said, adding that utilisation rates under the Australia ECTA have reached 84 per cent.

But awareness among MSMEs remains low, and certification infrastructure is underdeveloped across most other agreements. "Every firm with export potential must

understand the preferential access available to it and have the documentation and compliance support to use it," Pandey said.

He added that the sectors where India has negotiated the deepest tariff concessions - textiles, leather, engineering goods, pharmaceuticals, and marine products - need targeted PLI-type support to build the production capacity and quality standards required to exploit that access fully.

India must also accelerate standards alignment and regulatory upgradation to meet the compliance requirements of partner markets, Pandey said.

This includes developing

credible domestic certification systems, pursuing mutual recognition agreements that allow Indian testing and conformity assessment to be accepted abroad, and building the carbon accounting frameworks that the European market access will increasingly require.

"The firms that will benefit most from FTAs are those that can meet partner-country quality, traceability, and sustainability standards. Government support through technical assistance and soft financing for MSMEs to achieve these standards is essential," he said.

Further, he said that India's export landscape is shifting toward higher-value manufacturing.

Electronics has risen from 3.3 per cent to 7.9 per cent of the export basket over the last decade, machinery from 3.8 per cent to 6.9 per cent, and smartphones are now India's top exported commodity. But this shift carries structural vulnerabilities that grow as India moves up the value chain.

Delivery cost increased by about 19 per cent in Asia Pacific: Report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delivery cost has increased by about 19 per cent in the Asia Pacific, including India, between the March and May period on a year-over-year basis, logistics software-as-a-service firm Fareye said in a report.

The survey was conducted after the West Asia conflict erupted, which put pressure on fuel supplies and cost.

"The research finds that delivery costs across APAC have risen 18.9 per cent year-on-year on average. For India, where fuel prices, driver wages, and urban congestion are structural cost drivers, this number is not a surprise. What is a surprise is the nature of the blind spot: operators can see where cost lands (fuel, labour, vehicles, carrier bills) but not where it is actually created," the report released recently said.

In India, the first-attempt delivery failure rates in

dense urban markets can run as high as 20-30 per cent, which is one of the primary reasons for profit drain.

In the case of India's quick commerce sector, 10-minute, 20-minute delivery? has attracted billions in investment and dominated logistics headlines for three years.

However, the survey found predictable delivery time is preferred by most customers (41 per cent) over the fastest possible delivery (22 per cent).

"Customers do not primarily want faster. They

want to know when their delivery will arrive and trust that it will arrive then. The implication for India is significant: the capital flowing into speed infrastructure may be partially misdirected. Reliability, not velocity, is the premium product," the survey said.

The majority of operators (delivery service providers) said their customers are willing to pay extra for delivery.

The survey found that more Indian customers are willing to pay extra for the delivery of certain items.

PROSPECT

ICAI plans advanced forensic lab to aid small, medium practitioners

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chartered accountants' institute ICAI will be setting up an advanced forensic auditing lab in Hyderabad to help small and medium practitioners, its President Prasanna Kumar D has said. The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI) has more than five lakh members, including small and medium practitioners.

In a recent interview, Kumar said that forensic audit is a new area, and small and medium chartered accountant firms are not able to participate in large auditing works as they do not have the forensic audit capabilities.

Against this backdrop, the institute will be setting up an advanced forensic lab, which will be a "pay and use model". It will offer assignment-specific tools. "We are establishing an advance forensic auditing lab



at the Centre of Excellence (CoE) in Hyderabad. In next 2-3 months, we will launch it," Kumar said.

Meanwhile, there are larger Government efforts to have homegrown big accounting firms that can help create more opportunities in the country's growing economy and also compete at the scale of global players.

In February, the institute notified the global networking guidelines, paving the way for creating large home-grown domestic chartered accountant firms, wherein they can also collaborate with global networks.

Zydex unveils India's first silicate mineral paint to shield monsoon damage

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Zydex Paints has launched India's first silicate mineral paint technology, aiming to disrupt the ₹93,000-crore domestic paint market with a solution targeting monsoon-related wall damage.

"India's construction ecosystem is moving towards materials that deliver durability, sustainability and long-term protection," said Dr Ajay Ranka, Chairman & MD, Zydex Group. "We see significant opportunity to scale this category further," he added. Zydex reports strong market acceptance with repeat purchases and growing interest from builders and architects.

Every monsoon, buildings across India face damp walls, peeling paint, seepage and algae growth as humidity weakens surfaces from within. Unlike conventional paints that form a surface film, Zydex's



technology chemically bonds with the substrate, creating a breathable surface that allows trapped vapour to escape. This helps reduce dampness and surface deterioration linked to high moisture.

The move taps into a shift toward performance-led coatings. While decorative paints still lead the market, demand is rising for solutions offering durability and lifecycle value.

In Europe, silicate paints hold roughly 2 percent share. Similar adoption in India could create a ₹2,000-crore segment, significant for a market exposed to humidity and harsh weather.

A Movement Beyond a Moment: The Promise of Yoga 365



MONALISA
DASH

Over the past decade, yoga has evolved from a traditional Indian practice into a global movement for health and well-being. What began in 2015 as the observance of the International Day of Yoga (IDY) has today become one of the world's largest public wellness initiatives, bringing together millions across countries, cultures and communities through a shared commitment to holistic health.

Yet, the true success of yoga cannot be measured only by the scale of a single day's celebration. Its real transformative power lies in continuity — in the quiet discipline of practising yoga every day. This is the vision that informs Yoga 365, an initiative of the Ministry of Ayush aimed at transforming yoga from an annual event into a daily habit and a way of life.

As India moves towards the International Day of Yoga 2026, the Ministry has already initiated a nationwide 100-day countdown campaign to build momentum, deepen public engagement and encourage sustained participation. The campaign is not merely about organising events; it is about cultivating behavioural change and embedding wellness into everyday living.

The 100-day countdown began with the launch of Yoga Mahotsav-2026 at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi, where the Morarji Desai National



Institute of Yoga (MDNIY) entered into a partnership with the wellness platform Habuild to offer free daily online yoga sessions. This collaboration represents an important step in expanding accessibility and ensuring that guided yoga practice reaches citizens across geographies, age groups and lifestyles.

India today stands at a unique juncture. Awareness about yoga and traditional wellness systems is already remarkably high.

According to the National Sample Survey (NSS) 79th Round, awareness of systems such as yoga stands at nearly 95 percent in rural India and 96 percent in urban India. However, the number of people who practise yoga consistently every day remains comparatively smaller. This gap between awareness and regular practice is precisely where Yoga 365

seeks to intervene. The idea is simple: if millions can come together to celebrate yoga on one day, they can also integrate it into their everyday routines. Yoga 365 therefore focuses on encouraging sustained engagement through community outreach, institutional participation, digital platforms and behaviour-change communication.

The initiative aligns strongly with India's broader vision of preventive healthcare. In a world increasingly challenged by lifestyle disorders, stress-related illnesses and non-communicable diseases, yoga offers a low-cost, accessible and holistic pathway to wellness. Its benefits extend beyond physical fitness to mental clarity, emotional balance and social harmony.

Recognising this, the Ministry of Ayush has also introduced spe-

cialised yoga protocols for non-communicable diseases and target groups, making yoga more practical, evidence-based and relevant for contemporary health challenges.

Alongside this, programmes such as the Common Yoga Protocol (CYP), Y-Break for corporate professionals and therapeutic yoga modules are helping integrate yoga into workplaces, educational institutions and communities.

The ongoing countdown milestones have further demonstrated the growing public enthusiasm surrounding the movement. The 75-day countdown phase became a major milestone in scaling up outreach and citizen participation.

During Yoga Mahotsav 2026, a remarkable Asia Book of Records achievement was created through a collective practice of Trikonasana, symbolising both unity and the rising momentum of the yoga movement.

Similarly, the 50-day countdown emerged as a high-visibility phase that amplified awareness and accelerated participation across the country and internationally. One of its defining moments was the participation of over 6,000 individuals performing Bhujangasana together, setting another Asia record and reflecting the extraordinary public enthusiasm that yoga continues to inspire.

The forthcoming 25-day countdown event at the iconic Khajuraho Temples in Madhya Pradesh will further strengthen this journey by symbolically connecting India's timeless civilisational heritage with its contemporary wellness vision.

Such locations remind us that

yoga is not merely a physical exercise but a deeply rooted cultural philosophy that has guided human well-being for centuries.

Importantly, Yoga 365 is envisioned not as a standalone campaign but as an umbrella movement connecting institutions, communities, corporations, educational networks and citizens. Through partnerships and collective participation, the initiative seeks to make wellness a shared social culture rather than an individual activity.

The International Day of Yoga has already demonstrated India's ability to offer a universal message of harmony and well-being to the world. The participation of more than 26 crore people during IDY 2025 reflected the extraordinary scale and resonance of this movement globally. The next step now is to ensure that the spirit of yoga continues beyond June 21 and becomes integrated into daily life.

The future of healthcare will increasingly depend on prevention, balance and lifestyle-based wellness. Yoga offers exactly that — a sustainable pathway towards healthier individuals and healthier societies. Through Yoga 365, the Ministry of Ayush aims to encourage citizens to embrace yoga not occasionally, but consistently; not as an event, but as a habit.

Ultimately, the vision of Yoga 365 is both simple and transformative: to make wellness a daily practice, to strengthen preventive health across communities, and to inspire people to carry the spirit of yoga through all 365 days of the year.

The author is the Joint Secretary,
Ministry of Ayush

IRFC to raise ECB loan worth \$ 2 billion to finance large infra projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Indian Railway Finance Corporation is planning to mobilise \$2 billion through external commercial borrowing, primarily in Japanese yen, to fund business growth in the current financial year.

The external commercial borrowing (ECB) is part of the ₹70,000 crore resource mobilisation plan approved by the board of Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) for the ongoing financial year.

"We have just signed a loan agreement with the consortium of banks for raising an External Commercial Borrowing loan of JPY equivalent \$1.1 billion. Given the



pipeline of projects, we expect disbursements within the June quarter itself," IRFC Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said.

The ECB, being raised for JPY equivalent \$1.1 billion, has been tied up for a 5-year tenor and benchmarked to Overnight TONAR (Tokyo Overnight Average Rate).

The proceeds from this facil-

ity will be utilised towards financing projects with forward or backward linkage with the railway sector or any other project as may be approved by the company in compliance with the ECB guidelines.

This is the first ECB being raised by IRFC during FY27 after it had raised Japanese yen equivalent \$700 million across two ECB transactions in FY26.

LIC emerges as highest profit-making financial company in January-March quarter

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) has emerged as the highest profit-making firm in the Indian financial sector in the March quarter, netting a little over ₹23,400 crore.

Even among Central Public Sector Enterprises, the Corporation maintained the number one position for fourth-quarter profit for FY26.

Last week, LIC reported a 23 per cent jump in net profit to record ₹23,420 crore in the just concluded March quarter as compared to ₹19,013 crore in the corresponding period of the previous year..



The insurance behemoth was followed by the country's biggest lender State Bank of India (SBI), and the second-biggest lender HDFC Bank with profit of ₹19,684 crore and ₹19,221 crore, respectively,

during the fourth quarter, according to the financial numbers posted on exchanges.

However, SBI significantly outpaced LIC in annual profit, earning ₹80,032 crore in FY26 compared to LIC's ₹57,419 crore.

Similarly, HDFC Bank's profit stood at ₹74,670 crore while ICICI Bank posted a profit of ₹50,147 crore. Among other PSUs, Indian Oil Corporation (IOC) closed the fourth quarter with a net profit of ₹11,378 crore followed by Coal India at ₹10,839 crore, Power Finance Corporation (PFC) earned ₹8,598 crore and NTPC ₹8,747 crore as profit, as per the data available on stock exchanges.

DRI seizes 3 lakh sticks of smuggled foreign-origin cigarettes worth ₹45 lakh in UP's Gorakhpur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Gorakhpur

The DRI has seized 3,00,000 sticks of foreign-origin cigarettes worth around ₹45 lakh that were being smuggled from Myanmar into India and transported from Assam to Uttar Pradesh concealed inside a truck, officials said on Sunday.

Acting on specific intelligence inputs about a large consignment of smuggled cigarettes being transported under the cover of bamboo cuts, Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) officers mounted surveillance on National Highway-27 in Gorakhpur and monitored suspected vehicles coming from Assam, an official statement said.

After maintaining vigil for nearly 12 hours, officials intercepted a suspected truck in the early hours of May 23.

A detailed search of the vehicle revealed it was carrying 9.42 metric tonnes of bamboo cuts. Officials said that a specially fabricated secret cavity had been created behind the driver's cabin using welded steel partitions.

During inspection of the concealed



space, officers recovered 30 cartons containing 3,00,000 sticks of foreign-origin cigarettes of the brand "ESSE Lights Super Slim", the statement said.

The consignment was seized under Section 110 of the Customs Act, 1962, and the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act (COTPA), 2003. Further

investigation is underway, officials said.

Officials also said that with this seizure, the DRI has confiscated a total of 15,32,000 sticks of smuggled foreign-origin cigarettes, valued at approximately ₹2.32 crore, in various cases across Uttar Pradesh over the past eight months.

Assam CM reviews progress of new Assam Bhawan in Delhi

TONY DAS ■ Assam

Himanta Biswa Sarma on Sunday inspected the ongoing construction of the new Assam Bhawan in New Delhi and reviewed the progress of the project aimed at strengthening Assam's presence in the national Capital.

During the visit, the Chief Minister assessed the pace and quality of the construction work and interacted with officials supervising the project. Resident Commissioner of Assam Bhawan, Kavita Padmanabhan, was also present during the inspection.

Sarma directed officials to ensure that the project is completed within the stipu-



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma inspecting the progress of the upcoming Assam Bhawan in New Delhi

lated timeline while maintaining high construction standards. He stressed that no compromise should be made on the quality of work

or the execution of the planned facilities.

Officials briefed the Chief Minister on the current status of the construction and

informed him about efforts being made to accelerate the work in compliance with prescribed standards.

The upcoming Assam Bhawan, being constructed on Sardar Patel Marg, is expected to provide improved accommodation and administrative support facilities for people from Assam visiting Delhi.

The project is also seen as a key infrastructure initiative to enhance the State's institutional presence in the national Capital.

According to officials, the new building will include three basement levels, a ground floor and six upper floors.

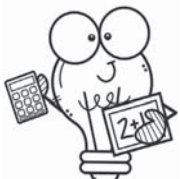
DAILY SUDOKU

6	2	1					4	
			9				2	6
	9				1			8
8		3	7	1				
				8	2	3		5
2			3				7	
	4	9			6			
	8					6	2	4

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

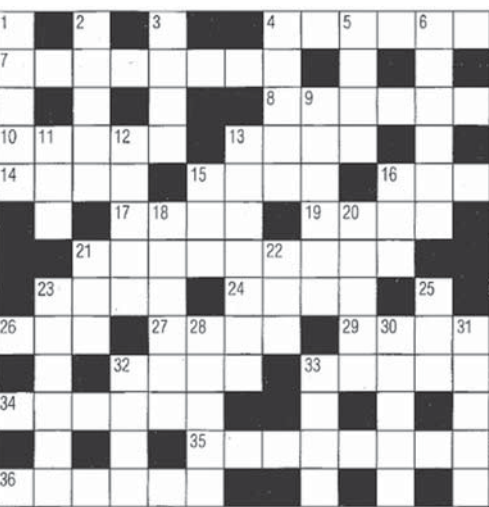
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (23.5.26)								
3	2	9	1	7	6	5	8	4
6	7	5	4	8	3	9	2	1
4	1	8	9	2	5	6	7	3
2	5	1	6	9	8	3	4	7
7	4	3	5	1	2	8	6	9
8	9	6	3	4	7	1	5	2
5	6	7	2	3	9	4	1	8
9	8	4	7	5	1	2	3	6
1	3	2	8	6	4	7	9	5

DOUBLE CROSSWORD MONDAY | MAY 25, 2026



ACROSS

- A miserable little room will be depressing (6)
- Makeup applied with aggressive intent (8)
- The shrewdness of men with some faculties (6)
- Not a healthy basis for walking (5)
- A juicy lump? (4)
- Tow-headed girl, a beautiful swimmer (4)
- Derision will dishearten a jester (4)
- Consumed not merely a bit of water (3)
- As worn by Tom to go round the job centre? (4)

DOWN

- The skinhead cried when brushed aside! (5)
- Sound of a maladjusted organ? (5)
- Riverside business establishment? (4)
- Old, initially sad story (5)
- Musical instrument possibly containing oil? (4)
- They happen to have a hole in the middle (6)
- A dog has to sit up with this cup (6)
- Lord of the courts (3)
- Wild crane with a beautiful greyish gloss (5)
- Wherein the appealing little creatures jump around? (7)
- Tomorrow's sweet promise? (3)

- They possess the arts of seamanship (4)
- Portion of chicken for the eater? (9)
- Distance over which there's a charge for finishing last? (4)
- Be quiet and listen to this! (4)
- Drink will make you less than alert (3)
- Flatten with a club (4)
- Music means nothing to a Manx cat (4)
- Shoot game! (4)
- President a head of government had to harangue? (5)
- Bob does so if pushed! (6)
- Noble, mature looking tea man (4,4)
- Cold, fat-headed and stiff (6)

- Noah's response when he heard the rain (3)
- A stunning treat? (6)
- He doesn't show his true feelings (5)
- Might one see a jay beside this river? (3)
- An element of tininess (3)
- To call this a river would be a bloomer (5)
- Demolished by the wild sea invading the road (5)
- Piano tunes as duos (5)
- Remains to help people with their figures (5)
- The catch that can mean trouble for the angler (4)
- Grand antique, precious (4)

SOLUTION (23.5.26)

- | | | | |
|--------------|---------------|---------------|-------------------------|
| ACROSS | 22. Cow-Ed | DOWN | 19. Tow |
| 1. Re-noir | 23. Ha-R-d | 1. Roused | 20. Dad (rev.) |
| 7. Aeronaut | 26. All-ow | 2. O.-new-ay | 21. Lowered |
| 8. Perm | 28. Tic | 3. Ramp | 22. Cot |
| 10. Show up | 29. Beater | 4. Co-n-ic-al | 23. Henley (-on-Thames) |
| 11. Bid-den | 30. Pun-ne-t | 5. Panda | 24. Ac-ne |
| 14. Sat | 31. O.-gle | 6. Stone | 25. Dotes-t |
| 16. Crane | 32. Over-eats | 8. Post | 26. Ab-b-ot |
| 17. Du-ty | 33. Try-out | 9. Rut | 27. Lat-er |
| 19. Today | | 12. Dr-y | 28. Tug |
| 21. L-O-y-al | | 13. Enter | 29. To-ye-d |
| | | 15. To-ye-d | 30. Post |
| | | 18. Uncle | |

BRIEFLY

Saptak Talwar drops to tied-56th in Denmark



After two fine rounds, India's Saptak Talwar faltered in the third, carding a 3-over 75 to drop down to Tied-56th at the Danish Golf Challenge. Talwar, who shot 67-70 on the first two days, is now 5-under for 54 holes. The Indian order of Merit leader at home had just one birdie against four bogeys. Arjun Prasad, the other Indian in the field, had missed the cut. Finland's Tapio Pulkkanen fired a second consecutive nine under par 63 on Saturday to take a three-shot lead into the final round. The 36-year-old from Finland made eight birdies and an eagle at Odense Eventyr Golf, in a round that included several lengthy putts and saw him cruise away from what was a tightly bunched pack. Pulkkanen currently sits 25th in the Road to Mallorca Rankings. Frenchman Maxence Giboudot and 36-hole co-leader Algot Kleen from Sweden are Pulkkanen's closest competitors, the pair shot nine under par and five under par respectively to be three shots behind of the leader. The final round of the Danish Golf Challenge begins at 8.00am local time, with Tapio Pulkkanen teeing off with Maxence Giboudot and Algot Kleen at 10.01am.

National Divyang T20 Meet: UP beat Mumbai to win title



Uttar Pradesh beat defending champions Mumbai by four wickets in an exciting final to win the fifth National Divyang T20 Cricket tournament here on Sunday. The championship was organized under the aegis of the Karnataka State Divyang Cricket Association (KSDCA), which is the state body of the Physically Challenged Cricket Council of India (PCCAI). Mumbai posted a competitive total of 171/7 in 20 overs. Ravindra Sante was unbeaten on 71 while Vikrant Keni contributed 54 runs. For Uttar Pradesh, Mohammed Sadik delivered an impressive bowling performance, taking 2/24. UP captain Rahul Singh provided a flying start with a quickfire 31 runs off just 13 balls. Vintoo Yadav scored a crucial 35 runs, while Deependra Singh anchored the innings with an unbeaten 54 runs to guide Uttar Pradesh to victory in 18.5 overs.

Davis Cup skipper Rohit Rajpal to be India's Chef de Mission at CWG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's Davis Cup captain Rohit Rajpal has been appointed as the country's Chef de Mission for the upcoming Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, according to IOA sources.

Ravi Bengani is the Deputy Chef de Mission, while Vandana Rao and Rahul Swami will travel with the Indian contingent as general team managers for the Games, scheduled to be held from July 23 to August 2.

Indian Olympic Association (IOA) president P T Usha will be part of the senior leadership delegation alongside CEO Raghuram Iyer and Vignesh Vengalil Ujjwal. Rajpal is an



Executive Committee member of the IOA and vice-president of the All India

Mandaviya unveils integrated sports facility at SAI NCoE

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Gandhinagar

Sports minster Mansukh Mandaviya on Sunday inaugurated several new sports infrastructure facilities at SAI NCoE Gandhinagar, reaffirming the government's commitment towards building world-class high-performance sporting ecosystems across the country.

The minister inaugurated the newly developed Para Athlete Hostel, Centralized Dining Hall, Strength & Conditioning Hall, Multipurpose Training Hall and Meditation Park at the centre.

The facilities have been developed to strengthen athlete preparation through integrated support in training,



recovery, nutrition, sports science and mental wellbeing. "Our record performances in recent international events are not accidental achievements. They are the result of sustained invest-

ment in athletes, scientific training, modern infrastructure and a strong belief that India can become a global sporting powerhouse," Mandaviya was quoted as saying in a PIB release.

NRAI names 22-member squad for Munich World Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India will field a 22-member squad at the ISSF Rifle/Pistol World Cup in Munich from May 24 to 31, with double Olympic medallist Manu Bhaker set to compete in two individual pistol events besides the mixed team competition.

The National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) on Sunday announced a squad blending experienced campaigners with young shooters for what is regarded as one of the sport's premier annual events.

Alongside Manu, Olympian and world championship medallist Esha Singh will also feature in two individual

pistol events as India's leading shooters return to top-level international competition away from home for the first time this season.

The competition will begin from May 26 with the women's 25m pistol precision stage. The qualification round of men's 10m air pistol and the elimination round of women's 50m rifle 3 positions will also be held on the opening day, along with qualification for the men's 10m air rifle event.

The first finals of the tournament -- men's 10m air pistol and men's 10m air rifle -- are also scheduled on the opening day.

A total of 696 shooters from 80 countries, including several Olympic and world



champions, are expected to compete at the Munich World Cup, which serves as a major preparatory event ahead of the World Championships and other marquee multi-sport competitions later this year.

India had won one gold medal at the season's first

AHMEDABAD LEADS CWG DAY AS FIT INDIA CYCLE DRIVE UNITES NATION

Ahmedabad: The 75th edition of Fit India Sundays on Cycle drew massive participation across more than 8,000 locations nationwide as the initiative commemorated Commonwealth Games Day and built momentum towards the historic 2030 Commonwealth Games (CWG) in Ahmedabad.

Leading the national celebrations from the iconic Sabarmati Riverfront, Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya, Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghvi and Bollywood actor Ayushmann Khurrana joined 5,000 cyclists, athletes, youth volunteers and fitness enthusiasts in a vibrant showcase of community participation and sporting spirit.

The Ahmedabad edition, themed "A New Icon for a Fitter India - Pedalling to 2030," featured a grand 5km cycling rally alongside yoga and zumba demonstrations. A major highlight of the event was the inauguration of a special Commonwealth Games-themed exhibition by Mandaviya, showcasing India's sporting achievements, the growth of sports infrastructure under the Khelo India Mission and the country's expanding sports ecosystem in the lead-up to the centenary CWG in 2030.



Pranati Nayak wins silver at FIG World Challenge Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India's Pranati Nayak clinched silver medal in the women's vault event at the FIG World Challenge Cup 2026 in Tashkent. The 31-year-old Odisha gymnast, a three-time Asian Championship medallist, secured an average score of 13.025 after registering 12.950 and 12.700 across her two vaults in the final on Saturday.

Vietnam's Thi Quynh Nhu Nguyen won the gold medal with a score of 13.375, while Uzbekistan's Shakhinabonu Yusufova claimed bronze with 12.950.

Another Indian finalist,



Protistha Samanta, finished sixth with a score of 12.850.

Reflecting on her achievement in a social media post, Pranati said the past few months had been challenging but credited perseverance and faith for helping her bounce back.

Gukesh, Praggnanandhaa lead India's charge at Norway Chess

AJAI MASAND
■ Oslo

World champion D Gukesh will have a shot at rediscovering his touch ahead of his world championship title defence when he launches his campaign at the prestigious Norway Chess on Monday, facing another stern test of temperament and skill against an elite field.

The elite field is headlined by former world Number 1 Magnus Carlsen and, besides Gukesh, also features Indian star R Praggnanandhaa, with a formidable Indian contingent aiming to end the country's long-standing wait for a maiden title in the picturesque surroundings of Oslo and its scenic fjords.

The carefully chosen venue, the iconic Deichman



Björvika public library overlooking the Oslofjord waterfront and located just a couple of kilometres from the Nobel Peace Center, will host six of the world's best players in both the Open and Women's sections.

India, now firmly established as a global chess pow-

erhouse, will have four representatives in the event -- Gukesh and Praggnanandhaa in the Open category, alongside Koneru Humpy and World Cup winner Divya Deshmukh in the women's field. The task, however, will be anything but easy for the Indian quartet, with world

No. 1 and home favourite Carlsen leading a formidable field that includes French star Alireza Firouzja, Germany's Vincent Keymer and seasoned American campaigner Wesley So.

Among the women, the field boasts five-time and reigning world champion Ju Wenjun, defending Norway Chess champion Anna Muzychuk, reigning world blitz champion Bibisara Assaubayeva and China's fast-rising star Zhu Jiner, alongside the two Indian representatives. Gukesh enters the tournament carrying the weight of expectation as the player tipped to challenge Carlsen's stranglehold over Norway Chess, a competition the Norwegian legend has won a record seven times.

Yet, after an underwhelm-

ing season so far, Gukesh is likely to treat the event as crucial preparation ahead of his World Championship title defence later this year against challenger Javokhir Sindarov.

Currently ranked world No. 19, Gukesh arrives in Oslo following a disappointing sixth-place finish at the Grand Chess Tour's Super Rapid and Blitz event in Poland.

However, memories of last year's dramatic victory over Carlsen in the tournament held last year in Stavanger -- a defeat that triggered the Norwegian's now-iconic table-bang in frustration -- could provide the Indian teenager the spark he needs.

Gukesh will hope to recreate that kind of statement performance this year to regain momentum and confidence before the World

Championship defence.

Meanwhile, Praggnanandhaa appears better primed for the challenge after a series of impressive battles against the likes of Keymer, So and Firouzja at the recently-concluded Superbet Chess Classic in Bucharest.

Having produced a few strong results there, Praggnanandhaa could carry valuable momentum into Oslo, especially with several familiar rivals from Bucharest once again standing across the board at Norway Chess.

In the women's section, Koneru Humpy will look to mount a strong challenge against undisputed world champion Ju Wenjun after opting out of the Candidates tournament in Cyprus because of the conflict in the Gulf region. (PTI)

Mansi Lather, Kajal, Sumit strike gold at U23 Asian Wrestling Championships

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Da Nang (Vietnam)

India's stellar run continued at the U23 Asian Wrestling Championships as Mansi Lather, Kajal and Sumit clinched gold medals to headline a dominant showing on the second day of the competition here on Sunday.

Mansi put up a dominant display in the 68kg gold medal bout, registering a comprehensive 14-1 win over Uzbekistan's Firuza Esenbaeva.

Kajal was equally impressive in the 76kg final, blanking Kyrgyzstan's Aizharkyn Zhanybekova 10-0, while Greco-Roman grappler Sumit



secured the 63kg title with a 12-2 victory over Uzbekistan's Ozodbek Khalilboev.

Alongside the three gold medals, the Indian contingent also secured two silver and three bronze.

Sweetie fought hard in her final but narrowly went down 5-7 against Vietnam's Ngoc L to settle for the

silver medal. Neha also put up a spirited fight in the 59kg title clash before suffering a 5-9 defeat at the hands of Uzbekistan's Laylokhon Sobirova, bringing home India's second silver of the day.

Meanwhile, Ahilya S. Shinde was impressive in her bronze medal playoff, securing a comprehensive 13-2 win over Kyrgyzstan's Arruke Kadyrbek Kyzy.

In the Greco-Roman category that carried over from the opening day, Neeraj Patel showcased brilliant technique in his 55kg match, blanking Kazakhstan's Rauan Bekimov 8-0 to comfortably claim the bronze medal.

Ecuador fans pin hopes on a World Cup run amid a surge in violence

GONZALO SOLANO
■ Guayaquil (Ecuador)

Ecuador could do with some good news. Many provinces are under a state of emergency. Thousands of military and police are fighting a surge in crime driven by drug traffickers. Night-time curfews abound. The fuel crisis has caused severe disruption. The border with Colombia is volatile.

But hope is high and undiminished for Ecuador at the coming World Cup.

The team qualified second in South America to World Cup champion Argentina, losing only twice in 18 games, both times away by one goal in Argentina and Brazil. Supporters of La Tri believe

they're good enough to surpass their previous best World Cup result, the round of 16 in 2006 in Germany, where Ecuador was ousted by a David Beckham free kick. "I bought a giant TV on credit so I could watch Ecuador win the World Cup," says Mario Uquillas, a 43-year-old shopkeeper from downtown Guayaquil.

"I hope that, at the very least, La Tri reaches the quarterfinals. It's about time, because we have a great team." Other merchants at the sprawling La Bahia market are taking advantage of the occasion, including offering Ecuador World Cup jerseys. The most popular feature the names of Arsenal defender Piero Hincapie,

Chelsea midfielder Moises Caicedo, and Paris Saint-Germain center back William Pacheco. Hincapie put smiles on the faces of Ecuador fans this week when Arsenal won the Premier League for the first time in 22 years.

Those supporters have another opportunity to see homegrown stars win a major trophy when Hincapie and Pacheco clash in the Champions League final next weekend.

Players murderedLocal soccer hasn't been immune to the country's violence. In fact, the local scene is stained with blood; five players were murdered last year and three more victims of armed attacks. The most dramatic case occurred last December



in northern Guayaquil when hitmen killed Mario Pineida, the left back of local club Guayaquil Barcelona and a former national team player.

Pineida was at a butcher shop with his mother and his

female partner when two attackers shot them repeatedly. The mother was wounded and the partner died. One of the gunmen was arrested but the motive for the attack remains

unclear. Guayaquil, 270 kilometers southwest of capital Quito, ranks eighth among the most violent cities in the Americas, according to the crime index of the international platform Numbeo.

Ecuador recorded 9,216 violent deaths last year, a rate of 50.1 per 100,000 inhabitants, according to the Ecuadorian Observatory of Organized Crime.

Living in the country's most violent city has led families to take precautions, especially in the sprawling slums, where children used to play soccer in the streets.

Now, at nightfall, they often lock themselves in their homes for fear of the frequent shootings, robberies, or attacks.

And, yet, in this environment soccer manages to thrive thanks to Guayaquil Barcelona, Ecuador's most popular club. It offers a dream of a better life, starting in the youth academy that once

briefly included Hincapie. But he wouldn't recognize the facilities now -- secure and guarded against organized crime. My dream is to be a pro! The soccer school caters for nearly 300 youths. Piero Ortega, aged 10, has been at the academy for five years.

"My dream is to play for PSG or Real Madrid," Ortega says. "My dream is to be a professional soccer player."

Shouts of instructions from coaches can be heard at the academy. Boys and girls chase after the ball and repeat actions to correct plays. They seem to never tire of running. Another 10-year-old, Washington Vera, controls the ball with great skill, eludes opponents, and delivers precise passes. (AP)

Rahul blitz, Kuldeep magic sink Kolkata in final league game

TAPAN MOHANTA ■ Kolkata

Kuldeep Yadav marked his return in a stunning three-wicket haul to complement KL Rahul's blazing half-century at the top as Delhi Capitals outclassed an out-of-sorts Kolkata Knight Riders by 40 runs, in an inconsequential final league match of the IPL here on Sunday.

Rahul was at his explosive best, smashing five fours and four sixes in a 30-ball 60, his sixth fifty of the season, as Delhi Capitals posted a formidable 203/5 after Ajinkya Rahane opted to bowl.

In reply, comeback left-arm wrist spinner Kuldeep tormented his former franchise with a decisive spell,

first removing Cameron Green (2) cheaply before striking twice in two balls to dismiss Rahane (63) and Rinku Singh (0) off successive deliveries.

He nearly claimed a hat-trick as well when KKR wicketkeeper Tejasvi Dahiya edged the very next delivery, only for Abhishek Porel to spill the chance behind the stumps.

Kuldeep, who had gone wicketless in his previous three matches before being left out, returned with brilliant figures of 3/29.

KKR's chase unravelled after Rahane's dismissal as they were bundled out for 163 in 18.4 overs to slump to their seventh defeat of the season.



Mitchell Starc, bowling against the franchise with whom he won the IPL title last season, also chipped in with 2/26 (3 overs).

Lungi Ngidi (3/27; 3.4 overs) took the last wicket of Varun Chakravarthi as Delhi Capitals finished with seven wins, seven losses to climb above KKR to finish sixth in the standings.

KKR ended seventh with six wins from 14 matches for yet another poor season under Rahane.

Under Rahane's leadership, KKR had endured a disappointing 2025 campaign as well, finishing eighth, the first time since 2009.

Possibly playing his final match for the franchise, the

37-year-old Rahane produced one of his finest knocks of the season to keep KKR in the chase. Express pacer Ngidi made early inroads, dismissing the dangerous Finn Allen (20) in the powerplay before removing Manish Pandey (25) when he was attempting to rebuild alongside Rahane.

Rahane, however, looked in sublime touch. He took on Augib Nabi with successive sixes over long-on and deep midwicket before launching Axar Patel for two back-to-back sixes to bring up a 31-ball half-century.

But Kuldeep had the final say. Sensing Rahane making room, the spinner followed him with a tossed-up delivery that dipped full outside leg stump.

Rahane attempted to loft it straight down the ground but only managed to slice it to David Miller, ending a superb 39-ball 63 studded with four fours and four sixes.

The contest had effectively turned into a dead rubber as early as the fourth over when the Rajasthan Royals defeated the Mumbai Indians by 30 runs elsewhere at the Wankhede Stadium to seal the fourth and final playoff berth.

The result knocked out both KKR and Punjab Kings, who had stayed alive with their win over Lucknow Super Giants on Saturday, while Delhi had already been eliminated after PBKS' victory.

Boards need to align better on players' availability through IPL: Mohit Burman

BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Calling foreign players' availability in the IPL a sensitive issue, Punjab Kings co-owner Mohit Burman observed that BCCI, foreign boards and other stakeholders can do better to ensure that overseas players are available through the world's biggest T20 league's duration.

The BCCI has a two-year ban in place for foreign players who pull out of the IPL after being bought in the auction with an exception made for injured cricketers.

Yet, foreign player availability, especially of star players, remains an issue. For example, Mitchell Starc was only cleared by Cricket Australia for the second half of this season's tournament and by that time Delhi Capitals' fate in the tournament was more or less sealed.

Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood too were not available for their respective IPL teams from day one of the tournament due to niggles.

Speaking to PTI, Burman spoke his mind on the touchy topic. "It is a sensitive issue because international cricket calendars are extremely crowded, and players also have commitments to their national boards. But ideally, when a player commits to a franchise, there should be as much clarity as possible around availability.

"From a franchise perspective, planning becomes difficult when key players are unavailable for significant portions of the tournament despite being major auction



investments.

"Fans also expect to see marquee players from the start of the season. At the same time, solutions have to come through collaboration rather than confrontation. The BCCI, franchises, players and international boards all need to align schedules better and create clearer commitments," said Burman, who owns 48 percent share of the Punjab franchise.

When asked earlier this month, Delhi Capitals head coach Hemang Badani had expressed his frustration on player availability especially when that team member is a trump card like Starc.

"Ideally, I would want my players to be available to me from day one. But if there are certain things decided by associations and governing bodies, there's very little that we can do," he had said.

"Because if Cricket Australia does not release him, which was also the case with Hazlewood, also the case with Pat Cummins, there's little a coach or any franchise can do about that. Hopefully, we have a solution to it in the future," said Badani. (PTI)

Jofra Archer powers RR into IPL playoffs with win over MI

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Rajasthan Royals rode on Jofra Archer's all-round brilliance to book the fourth and final play-off berth with a 30-run victory over Mumbai Indians in the Indian Premier League here on Sunday.

Archer returned with splendid figures of 4-0-17-3 after his 15-ball 32 helped Royals reach a fighting 205 for 8 after 20 overs.

It was 73 runs in the last five overs bowled by Mumbai Indians which proved to be decisive as Mumbai Indians could manage only 175 for 9 in 20 overs.

The victory lifted Rajasthan Royals to the fourth position in the IPL points table with 16 points, effectively knocking out Punjab Kings, Kolkata

Knight Riders, and even Delhi Capitals - latter two had slim outside chances.

Mumbai Indians' reply was spruced with a timely half-century from Suryakumar Yadav — 60 off 42 balls with four sixes and three fours - as well as skipper Hardik Pandya's 15-ball 34 and Will Jacks' 33 off 18 balls.

But none of these efforts were enough to revive the five-time winners, who had slipped to 38 for four with Archer's two-wicket burst at the start.

The collapse began when Archer produced a jaffa — a perfect outswinger which darted sharply away from Rohit Sharma (0) who went on a fishing expedition away from his body. The resultant edge settled into wicket-



keeper Dhruv Jurel's gloves.

Archer then got one to nip off the surface to hit the wickets and see the back of Naman Dhir (6) in the third over, but the body blow came for MI in the form of Ryan Rickelton's (12) dismissal off Burger, who found

Vaibhav Sooryavanshi at square leg.

A disappointing season had no different end for Tilak Varma with the bat when the India batter was undone by a Brijesh Sharma delivery which kept low while he attempted to flick it.

Players try to be role models but can fail: Gavaskar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Legendary Sunil Gavaskar on Sunday said every player tries to become a role model while rising through the ranks but it is only human to fail to live up to the standards at times.

Without touching upon any specific incident that has happened in this year's Indian Premier League, Gavaskar said social media tools carry information and messages to the general public much sooner than in the past.

"In the heat of the moment things happen, it is not that you teach youngsters anything, anybody can snap, (and) that is what happens," Gavaskar told



reporters at the launch of Midwicket Stories here.

"Everybody tries to be, once you start getting up there, to be the best role model that they can be. That is just how you're brought up."

"You want to be the best role model. (But) all of us are human so all of us, some time will fail that standard. Today it is in the public domain a lot sooner than it was in the past," he said.

Need to consider a reset: Tom Moody hints at leadership change at LSG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Lucknow Super Giants are set to consider a leadership overhaul after enduring two dismal IPL campaigns, with Director of Cricket Tom Moody admitting skipper Rishabh Pant has struggled to handle the pressures of captaincy.

After finishing seventh in 2025, LSG are set to end the 2026 season in either ninth or 10th place, depending on Mumbai Indians' final result. Under Pant's captaincy, the franchise managed only 10 wins in 28 matches across two seasons.

"From a captaincy point of view, you know, he's found it challenging, obviously, and the results reflect that,"

Moody said told reporters after the seven-wicket loss to Punjab Kings on Saturday.

"And you do have to wonder whether that is a pressure that is reflected with his performance with the bat. I know that this season has been a difficult season for us, but we will reflect on it, we'll take time, we'll reflect on it. We'll consider all things."

Pant, already under intense scrutiny after being brought for a record breaking Rs 27 crore, has also struggled to make a significant impact with the bat.

Widely regarded as one of India's most destructive batters, the wicketkeeper-opener enjoyed stellar seasons in 2018 when he scored 684 runs at a strike



rate of 173.60, and in 2019, when he amassed 488 runs at 162.66.

However, he has failed to recreate that impact at LSG, scoring 581 runs at a strike rate of 135.74 across two

seasons, below his career strike rate of 144.18.

Moody's comments come days after Pant lost India's Test vice-captaincy to KL Rahul and was dropped from the ODI squad.

"But certainly we haven't lived up to the expectation or the standard that we expect of ourselves. And certainly when it comes to the leadership of the franchise, it's certainly something that we'll be taking some very serious consideration to, you know, what it looks like in the future."

"Like every department, when you do reflect on a season, we will be making some considered decisions, but it certainly looks like that we're needing to consider a reset."

Despite the disappointing campaign, Moody refrained from singling out individuals and instead accepted collective responsibility for the team's struggles.

"We're all responsible (for the disappointing season),"

Moody said.

"I don't think it's a time to point the finger at any individual. We all take accountability, and now's not the time to be apportioning blame in any particular department."

"We all need time to reflect on it in a calm manner, but there's certain things that we do need to address, and that will be addressed." Meanwhile, Punjab Kings snapped a seven-match losing streak with a seven-wicket victory over LSG to keep their playoff hopes alive. However, PBKS' qualification chances now depend on Sunday's clash between Rajasthan Royals, who are on 14 points, and the already-eliminated Mumbai Indians.

I have taken a lot of brave calls this season: RR skipper Riyan Parag



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Rajasthan Royals skipper Riyan Parag on Sunday said he trusts his instincts while making on-field decisions and credited a series of "brave" calls for the team's entry into this season's IPL playoffs after a 30-run win over Mumbai Indians.

RR posted 205 for eight before restricting MI to 175 for nine to clinch the final playoff spot, knocking out Punjab Kings and Kolkata Knight Riders in the process.

"I've taken a lot of brave calls this season, that's how I like to lead. I thought only Archer could get Hardik, and that's what he did. I always go with instincts over numbers in real-time decisions," Parag said during the post-match presentation.

Parag's tactical moves paid off as Jofra Archer smashed 32 off 15 balls after being promoted up the order and later returned figures of three for 17 with the ball, including wickets of Rohit Sharma and

Hardik Pandya.

"Feels good when things go to plan. We've won but there are a lot of things we need to do better."

"I wanted the set batter to play longer, we needed runs. We can't have two batters go at a run a ball. That's why we sent Jadeja, we wanted a quick 20 from him, which he provided." The Assamese cricketer said he is not 100 percent fit yet but exuded confidence of playing in the playoffs. "I was definitely not fit, I wasn't supposed to play today or the next game. Will definitely play the next game. Jofra is strong as a rock. Jaddu's strong, he's a warrior. We should've qualified way earlier. We're picking slack."

RR Director of Cricket Kumar Sangakkara credited the bowlers for holding their nerves in pressure moments.

"During the last timeout it was just about sticking to plans and holding your nerve. All the bowlers did a brilliant job," Sangakkara said. He also explained the decision to promote Archer up the order.

DDCA scraps complimentary passes for members to curb black-marketing, boost revenue

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH ■ New Delhi

The Delhi & District Cricket Association (DDCA) will stop issuing complimentary passes to members to enhance transparency and prevent revenue losses.

The Apex Council made this decision during a meeting on Sunday, following recent events regarding the ticket black market. DDCA President Rohan Jaitley chaired the session. With

immediate effect, the association will no longer accept complimentary passes from IPL franchises, such as the Delhi Capitals, for bilateral and international matches at Arun Jaitley Stadium.

Under the new policy, each DDCA member will receive only two complimentary tickets for Gates 17-18, which may include a buffet lunch.

Officials believe this move will help generate more revenue for the cash-strapped body. For example,

a senior DDCA official estimates that the association can earn up to ₹1 crore in ticket sales during high-profile bilateral matches.

The decision follows recent allegations of black-marketing of complimentary passes during IPL 2026 at Arun Jaitley Stadium, which led to a police investigation.

The series of events began when Delhi Police uncovered an organised ticket racket. Investigators found that a senior DDCA official



allegedly diverted up to 1,200 passes per match, marked "Not for Sale," for resale at prices ranging from ₹8,000 to ₹80,000.

A breakthrough in the investigation occurred on

May 8, 2026, when police arrested three men, Mukem, Gufran alias Sajid, and Md Faisal, outside the stadium. They were allegedly attempting to sell complimentary passes for that day's IPL match, and police recovered 54 tickets (33 of which were complimentary) and ₹25,000 in cash.

Further interrogation led police to Pankaj Yadav, a nearby petrol pump supervisor, who was identified as the alleged "distribution in-

charge" of the racket and subsequently arrested.

Each IPL match, DDCA receives about 6,000 complimentary passes from the franchise. Many of these, including undelivered passes, were allegedly given to Yadav, who then used a network stationed at stadium gates to sell them to fans. Ticket prices varied by match importance, ranging from ₹8,000 for regular games up to ₹80,000 for high-profile matches featur-

ing star players like Virat Kohli.

Investigators suspect the illegal ticket network extended further, alleging that those involved supplied high-priced passes to individuals engaged in live betting operations at stadiums.

Police also found links to pickpockets and criminal elements, uncovering, during the May 2026 probe, links to similar black-market activities at other IPL venues across India.

As the investigation widened, Delhi Police summoned four DDCA officials, including two senior officers, for extended questioning. Formal notices were subsequently sent to two CEO-level officials and a personal assistant from the DDCA accounts section.

These individuals, responsible for pass distribution, were asked by police to explain the process that led to the reselling of passes on the black market.